Museo Nacional Thyssen-Bornemisza

A walk down through seven centuries of Western painting — from Duccio and the Renaissance to Hopper, Pollock and Pop



“Seven centuries of Western painting, gathered under one roof.”

— the Thyssen-Bornemisza Collection

70 TRACKS · APPROXIMATELY 114 MINUTES · ENGLISH

A walk down through seven centuries —
from Duccio and the Renaissance to Hopper, Pollock and Pop.

How to use this guide

This is a walk-through audio guide to the Museo Nacional Thyssen-Bornemisza, the third corner of Madrid's Golden Triangle of Art — a privately built, encyclopaedic survey of seven centuries of Western painting. It follows the museum's own top-down route: you start at the top, on Level 2 in the thirteenth century, and walk downward through time — Level 2 (Old Masters), Level 1 (the 19th and 20th centuries, America to Pop), and Level 0 (the Carmen Thyssen Collection). The guide is built around two kinds of tracks. Knowing the difference will let you move at your own pace.

Room introductions

Most tracks are short room introductions. Play one as you walk into a new room: it tells you what's there, what to look at first, and which works have their own dedicated track. In the header these are marked R-INTRO. They usually run between one and a half and two and a half minutes.

Single-work tracks

The rest focus on a single painting or sculpture. Play one when you are standing in front of the work it describes; in the header these are marked W-FOCUS. They usually run between two and three minutes.

Numbers and room signs

Every track carries a number — 001, 002, and so on — in the order you walk the tour, and the audio files are numbered to match, so you can simply play them in sequence. The room numbers printed at the top of each track come straight from the museum's own floor plan and match the gallery signs. They are stable — the Thyssen is not mid-rehang — but individual works do travel (see below).

Pauses and movement

Each track ends with a short silent pause built into the audio. That's your moment to look, photograph if you want to, and walk to the next stop. When you reach a new room, play the next track. When you're standing in front of a marquee work, play its dedicated track. The audio always tells you what to play next at the end of each track. You don't have to remember anything.

On honesty and change

The Thyssen lends generously to exhibitions worldwide, so on any given day a particular painting may be off the wall, with a notice in its place — the museum says as much on its own plan. The room layout itself is stable, but if a work you came for is travelling, that is why. Check the live notices at museothyssen.org before you go. A handful of works named here also rotate with the Carmen Thyssen deposit.

The visit, in shape

T00 at the entrance → up to Level 2 for the Early Renaissance, German and Venetian painting and the Baroque, the Dutch Golden Age, and the 18th century to Goya → down to Level 1 for 19th-century America and the Impressionists, Expressionism and the avant-gardes, and America's rise from abstraction to Pop → down to Level 0 for the Carmen Thyssen Collection → T-LAST on the way out. It runs around two and a half hours at an unhurried pace.

Contents

70 tracks · approximately 114 minutes of English narration. The first column is the play order, which matches the numbered audio files; the second is the official gallery room. Each track is short enough to listen to standing in front of a work; long enough to give the work its weight.

Opening

001	—	Welcome to the Thyssen-Bornemisza	ANCHOR	~2 min

Level 2 · The Early Renaissance

002	1–5	The age of gold and the birth of the face	R-INTRO	~1 min
003	1	Duccio, *Christ and the Samaritan Woman*	W-FOCUS	~2 min
004	3	Jan van Eyck, *The Annunciation Diptych*	W-FOCUS	~2 min
005	3	Hans Memling, *Portrait of a Young Man Praying*	W-FOCUS	~2 min
006	3	Petrus Christus, *Our Lady of the Dry Tree*	W-FOCUS	~2 min
007	5	Vittore Carpaccio, *Young Knight in a Landscape*	W-FOCUS	~2 min
008	4	Antonello da Messina, *Portrait of a Man*	W-FOCUS	~2 min
009	5	Domenico Ghirlandaio, *Portrait of Giovanna degli Albizzi Tornabuoni*	W-FOCUS	~2 min

Level 2 · Germany, Venice & the Baroque

010	8–9	The German eye	R-INTRO	~1 min
011	8	Albrecht Dürer, *Jesus Among the Doctors*	W-FOCUS	~2 min
012	8	Lucas Cranach the Elder, *The Nymph at the Fountain*	W-FOCUS	~2 min
013	8–9	Hans Holbein the Younger, *Portrait of Henry VIII of England*	W-FOCUS	~2 min
014	11	Venice: painting becomes colour	R-INTRO	~1 min
015	11	Titian, *The Penitent Saint Jerome*	W-FOCUS	~2 min
016	11	El Greco, *The Annunciation*	W-FOCUS	~2 min
017	12	The Baroque: a knock at the door	R-INTRO	~1 min
018	12	Caravaggio, *Saint Catherine of Alexandria*	W-FOCUS	~2 min
019	13–15	Peter Paul Rubens, *Venus and Cupid*	W-FOCUS	~2 min
020	13–15	Francisco de Zurbarán, *Saint Casilda*	W-FOCUS	~2 min

Level 2 · The Dutch Golden Age

021	23–28	Holland: a republic of ordinary things	R-INTRO	~1 min
022	27	Rembrandt, *Self-portrait wearing a hat and two Chains*	W-FOCUS	~2 min
023	27	Frans Hals, *Family Group in a Landscape*	W-FOCUS	~2 min

024	23	Pieter Saenredam, *The West Façade of the Church of Saint Mary in Utrecht*	W-FOCUS	~1 min
025	26–28	Dutch landscape	W-FOCUS	~2 min

Level 2 · The 18th Century & Romanticism

026	16–24	The Grand Tour: elegance and the view	R-INTRO	~1 min
027	16–22	Canaletto, *The Grand Canal from San Vio, Venice*	W-FOCUS	~2 min
028	24	Jean-Honoré Fragonard, *The See-Saw*	W-FOCUS	~2 min
029	24	Thomas Gainsborough, *Portrait of Sarah Buxton*	W-FOCUS	~2 min
030	29	1800: the world cracks open	R-INTRO	~1 min
031	29	Francisco de Goya, *Tío Paquete*	W-FOCUS	~2 min
032	29	Caspar David Friedrich, *Easter Morning*	W-FOCUS	~2 min

Level 1 · America & the Impressionists

033	30–32	Down a floor, across an ocean: America	R-INTRO	~1 min
034	31	The American sublime: Cole, Church and the Hudson River School	W-FOCUS	~2 min
035	32	John Singer Sargent, *Portrait of Millicent, Duchess of Sutherland*	W-FOCUS	~2 min
036	33	Paris, 1874: the light moves	R-INTRO	~1 min
037	33	Édouard Manet, *Horsewoman, Full-Face (L'Amazone)*	W-FOCUS	~2 min
038	33	Edgar Degas, *Swaying Dancer (Dancer in Green)*	W-FOCUS	~2 min
039	33	Claude Monet, *Charing Cross Bridge*	W-FOCUS	~2 min
040	33	Berthe Morisot and Mary Cassatt	W-FOCUS	~2 min
041	33	Vincent van Gogh, *Les Vessenots in Auvers*	W-FOCUS	~2 min
042	33	Paul Cézanne, *Seated Man*	W-FOCUS	~2 min

Level 1 · Expressionism & the Avant-Gardes

043	34–35	Germany screams in colour: Expressionism	R-INTRO	~1 min
044	35	Ernst Ludwig Kirchner, *Fränzi in front of a Carved Chair*	W-FOCUS	~2 min
045	35	Otto Dix, *Hugo Erfurth with Dog*	W-FOCUS	~2 min
046	34	Franz Marc, *The Dream*	W-FOCUS	~2 min
047	40	André Derain, *Waterloo Bridge*	W-FOCUS	~2 min
048	39–43	Painting lets go of the world: abstraction	R-INTRO	~1 min
049	39	Wassily Kandinsky, *Picture with Three Spots*	W-FOCUS	~2 min
050	43	Piet Mondrian, *Composition No. XIII (Composition 2)*	W-FOCUS	~2 min
051	43	El Lissitzky, *Proun 1 C*	W-FOCUS	~2 min

052	**41–42**	Cubism: the world in pieces	R-INTRO	~1 min
053	**41**	Pablo Picasso, *Harlequin with a Mirror*	W-FOCUS	~2 min
054	**41–42**	Braque, Gris and the Cubist tradition	W-FOCUS	~1 min
055	**44**	Dada and the dream: Surrealism	R-INTRO	~1 min
056	**44**	Salvador Dalí, *Dream Caused by the Flight of a Bee around a Pomegranate a Second before Waking*	W-FOCUS	~2 min
057	**44**	Max Ernst, Tanguy and the Surrealist unconscious	W-FOCUS	~2 min

Level 1 · America Leads — Abstraction to Pop

058	**46–49**	The centre of art crosses the Atlantic	R-INTRO	~1 min
059	**46**	Georgia O'Keeffe, *From the Plains II*	W-FOCUS	~2 min
060	**45**	Edward Hopper, *Hotel Room*	W-FOCUS	~2 min
061	**48**	Jackson Pollock, *Brown and Silver I*	W-FOCUS	~2 min
062	**49**	Francis Bacon, *Portrait of George Dyer in a Mirror*	W-FOCUS	~2 min
063	**52–56**	Pop: art eats the supermarket	R-INTRO	~1 min
064	**52**	Roy Lichtenstein, *Woman in Bath*	W-FOCUS	~2 min
065	**53–56**	Robert Rauschenberg, *Express*	W-FOCUS	~2 min

Level 0 · The Carmen Thyssen Collection

066	**Rooms A–J**	A second collection, a second eye	R-INTRO	~2 min
067	**Room F**	Paul Gauguin, *Mata Mua (In Olden Times)*	W-FOCUS	~2 min
068	**Rooms B–E**	John Constable and the Baroness's landscapes	W-FOCUS	~2 min
069	**Rooms H–I**	Natalia Goncharova, *Fishing*	W-FOCUS	~2 min

Closing

070	**Closing**	Out into the Paseo del Arte	CLOSE	~2 min

TRACK 001 ANCHOR 295 WORDS · ~2 MIN

Welcome to the Thyssen-Bornemisza

Welcome. Take a breath — you've arrived at the third corner of Madrid's Golden Triangle of Art, and in some ways the most surprising one.

You may have just come from the Prado, with its Spanish kings and Velázquez and Goya, or from the Reina Sofía, with Picasso's *Guernica* and the wild twentieth century. This museum is the bridge between them — and it fills in everything the other two leave out. Early Italian gold-ground panels. The Northern Renaissance. German painting. The Dutch Golden Age. The Grand Tour. Nineteenth-century America. German Expressionism. Russian abstraction. Pop. Where the Prado is Spanish and royal, and the Reina Sofía is Spanish and modern, the Thyssen is the whole story of Western painting, seven centuries of it, under one roof.

And here's the remarkable part: almost none of this belonged to Spain until recently. This is a *private* collection — assembled across two generations by one family, the Thyssen-Bornemiszas, German-Hungarian industrialists, who set out quite deliberately to own one outstanding example of every chapter in the history of painting. Spain bought the whole thing in 1993, and it has been completing the triangle ever since.

A word on how this tour works, because it shapes everything. The museum is built to be walked from the **top down**. You'll start on Level 2, in the thirteenth century, and as you descend through the building you'll move *forward* through time — down a floor, forward a few hundred years — until you step out the bottom into the present. It's one of the most satisfying walks in any museum in the world: the entire history of Western art, taken as a single gentle downhill stroll.

So — to the top. Let's begin in the age of gold leaf and saints.

TRACK 002 · 1–5 R-INTRO 185 WORDS · ~1 MIN

The age of gold and the birth of the face

WHERE YOU ARE

Ground floor, Rooms 1–5 — the start of the tour and the oldest works.

WHAT YOU SEE

Late-medieval and early-Renaissance panels: Duccio, Van Eyck, Memling, Antonello.

LISTEN FOR

How painting climbs out of flat gold and learns to build space, faces and the individual.

You're at the top of the building and the top of the story — the earliest rooms, where Western painting is just teaching itself to walk. Take these first galleries slowly; they cover nearly two hundred years, from the early 1300s to about 1500, and you can almost watch art change its mind as you go.

It begins with gold. The first panels glow with beaten gold-leaf backgrounds, because their world wasn't the everyday one — it was the eternal, heavenly space of saints and scripture, made for altars and prayer. Then, room by room, something extraordinary happens: the gold drains away and is replaced by sky, landscape, a real window, a real face. Artists in Italy and in the north — Flanders especially — start looking hard at the actual world, and at actual people.

Watch for that shift as you move not far on. The single biggest invention in these rooms isn't a technique — it's the *individual*: the portrait of one specific human being, looking out at you across five centuries. The very first of them are a few steps on.

TRACK 003 · 1 W-FOCUS 222 WORDS · ~2 MIN

Duccio, *Christ and the Samaritan Woman*

WHERE YOU ARE

Room 1, the gold-ground rooms — a small panel glowing with gold.

WHAT YOU SEE

Duccio, *Christ and the Samaritan Woman*, 1310–11 — tempera and gold on panel.

LISTEN FOR

How a Sienese master cracked open the flat gold world and let real space — and a real conversation — begin.

One of the oldest paintings in the museum — a small, jewel-like panel against a flat gold ground, with slender figures at a well outside a walled pink-and-cream town.

Christ and the Samaritan Woman, painted around 1310 by Duccio di Buoninsegna, the founding master of the Sienese school. It's a small scene from the back of his greatest work, the *Maestà*, the colossal double-sided altarpiece made for Siena's cathedral — when that altarpiece was later broken up, predella panels like this one scattered into collections around the world.

Look at what Duccio is reaching for. The background is still medieval gold, the holy non-space of an icon — but the town behind the figures is a real architectural place, with arches and a gate, and the figures themselves have weight and gesture and a quiet human exchange passing between them. Christ meets a woman at a well and asks her for water; she's surprised he'd even speak to her. It's one of the first moments in European painting where you feel a genuine *conversation* happening between two people. Duccio is standing right on the hinge between the icon and the picture — one foot in heaven's gold, one foot in the world. Everything else on these floors grows from this moment. The northern painters took the next step, close by.

TRACK 004 · 3 W-FOCUS 204 WORDS · ~2 MIN

Jan van Eyck, *The Annunciation Diptych*

WHERE YOU ARE

Room 3 — a tiny grisaille diptych painted to look like carved stone.

WHAT YOU SEE

Jan van Eyck, *The Annunciation Diptych*, c. 1433–35 — oil on panel.

LISTEN FOR

How Van Eyck fakes sculpture in paint so well your eye refuses to believe it's flat.

Two narrow panels, side by side, that look at first like carved stone statues in shadowy niches — until you realise they're paintings, pretending.

A diptych of *The Annunciation* by Jan van Eyck, the Flemish genius who, around 1433–35, did things with oil paint nobody had done before. The angel Gabriel on one side, the Virgin Mary on the other — but painted entirely in cool grey, *grisaille*, to imitate sculpture, complete with the illusion of stone niches, cast shadows, and even reflections in the polished black bases.

This is a magic trick four hundred years ahead of its time. Van Eyck is showing off — painting is so powerful, he's saying, that it can perfectly counterfeit a rival art form, sculpture, and then go further, adding reflections and light that real stone could never hold. Get close and look at the bases: the figures seem to be reflected in the dark marble beneath them. Van Eyck was among the first to truly master oil paint — building up colour and light in thin, glowing layers — and that technical revolution, born in Flanders, would change everything. He makes you doubt your own eyes. That's the point. More northern marvels are just here.

TRACK 005 · 3 W-FOCUS 214 WORDS · ~2 MIN

Hans Memling, *Portrait of a Young Man Praying*

WHERE YOU ARE

Room 3 — a young man with hands pressed together in prayer.

WHAT YOU SEE

Hans Memling, *Portrait of a Young Man Praying*, c. 1485 — oil on panel.

LISTEN FOR

Why this half of a lost diptych once faced a Madonna — and what the sitter is really looking at.

A small, intensely still panel — a young man in three-quarter view, his hands pressed together in prayer, set against a calm landscape that opens out behind him.

Portrait of a Young Man Praying, painted around 1485 by Hans Memling, the most sought-after portraitist of late-fifteenth-century Bruges. The praying pose is a clue: this panel was once part of a larger devotional ensemble — a triptych or diptych — the young man's gaze and folded hands directed toward a now-separated image of the Virgin and Child.

Memling all but invented the modern portrait formula that would rule for centuries — the sitter turned slightly, set not against flat gold but against a real sky and landscape that gives him weight and presence in the world. The face is calm, refined, a little melancholy; the sitter, never identified, was probably an Italian merchant living in Bruges, where Memling worked for the city's wealthy foreign community. And here's the hidden marvel: on the *reverse* of this very panel Memling painted a small vase of flowers — one of the earliest independent still lifes in all of European art, its irises and lilies quietly standing in for the purity of the Virgin. Total attention, front and back. Another tiny northern jewel is a little way on.

TRACK 006 · 3 W-FOCUS 198 WORDS · ~2 MIN

Petrus Christus, *Our Lady of the Dry Tree*

WHERE YOU ARE

Room 3 — a miniature Madonna in a dead, thorny tree hung with letters.

WHAT YOU SEE

Petrus Christus, *Our Lady of the Dry Tree*, c. 1465 — oil on panel.

LISTEN FOR

The strange medieval symbol behind this tiny picture, and the gold letters in the branches.

A very small panel — easy to walk past — of the Virgin and Child standing inside the branches of a bare, thorny, leafless tree, with tiny golden letters hanging from the twigs.

Our Lady of the Dry Tree, painted around 1465 by Petrus Christus, who took over as Bruges's leading painter after van Eyck. Those fifteen little golden objects dangling in the branches are the letter "A" — for *Ave*, the opening of the prayer *Ave Maria* — so the whole image is a visual rosary, a prayer you look at rather than say.

The dead, thorny tree is the key. It comes from a vision in the Old Testament and stood for fallen, barren humanity — the world after Eden, dry and cursed. And in the middle of it, blooming where nothing should grow, is Mary with Christ: new life, redemption, the dead wood made to flower. It's a complete theology compressed into something the size of a paperback, made for private devotion in someone's hands. Northern painters loved this — enormous meaning packed into tiny, perfect objects. Now Italy answers, with two of the first true portraits in Western art, just along here.

TRACK 007 · 5 W-FOCUS 203 WORDS · ~2 MIN

Vittore Carpaccio, *Young Knight in a Landscape*

WHERE YOU ARE

Room 5 — a young knight in armour in a teeming landscape.

WHAT YOU SEE

Vittore Carpaccio, *Young Knight in a Landscape*, 1505 — oil on canvas.

LISTEN FOR

One of the first full-length portraits in Western art, and the puzzle of who he is.

A striking full-length figure — a young man in gleaming armour, standing in a crowded landscape teeming with plants, birds and animals.

Young Knight in a Landscape, painted around 1505 by the Venetian Vittore Carpaccio. It's one of the earliest full-length portraits in all of Western art — at a time when portraits were almost always just the head and shoulders, Carpaccio dared to paint a whole standing man, life-size, head to armoured foot.

And he filled the world around the knight with meaning. Look closely and the landscape is alive with symbols — an ermine (a creature said to die rather than dirty itself, an emblem of purity), birds, flowers, a distant town, even a scroll with a Latin motto that translates as something like "better death than dishonour." Scholars still argue over exactly who the young man is, but the message is unmistakable: this is a portrait of *virtue*, of chivalric honour made visible. Carpaccio gives you a person and, at the same time, an entire moral world for them to stand in. After this, full-length portraiture was on the table for everyone. And right beside it hangs one of the sharpest faces in the building — just here.

TRACK 008 · 4 W-FOCUS 200 WORDS · ~2 MIN

Antonello da Messina, *Portrait of a Man*

WHERE YOU ARE

Room 4 — a man looking straight out at you, close and alive.

WHAT YOU SEE

Antonello da Messina, *Portrait of a Man*, c. 1475 — oil on panel.

LISTEN FOR

How a Sicilian carried the new oil technique south and made a face feel utterly present.

A small head-and-shoulders portrait of a man against a dark ground, turned slightly toward you, with eyes so alert he seems about to speak.

A *Portrait of a Man* by Antonello da Messina, the Sicilian painter who did something historically huge: he carried the northern, Flemish mastery of oil paint south into Italy. Trained in the orbit of painters who knew the van Eyck upheaval, Antonello fused that jewel-like northern precision with the solid, sculptural weight of Italian form.

The result is a face that feels uncannily *present*. Where Italian portraits had often shown the sitter in flat profile, like a head on a coin, Antonello turns the man to a three-quarter view and lights him from the side, so he occupies real space and meets your eye. Every detail — the stubble, the slight asymmetry, the wary intelligence in the gaze — is observed, not idealised. When Antonello brought this technique to Venice in the 1470s, it electrified painters there; Giovanni Bellini and the whole Venetian school took note. You're looking at a hinge point in the history of the portrait. And now the most famous face in the museum, the woman on the cover, is just ahead.

TRACK 009 · 5 W-FOCUS 278 WORDS · ~2 MIN

Domenico Ghirlandaio, *Portrait of Giovanna degli Albizzi Tornabuoni*

WHERE YOU ARE

Room 5 — a Florentine woman in strict profile, richly dressed.

WHAT YOU SEE

Domenico Ghirlandaio, *Portrait of Giovanna Tornabuoni*, 1489–90 — tempera on panel.

LISTEN FOR

Why she faces sideways, the Latin verse behind her, and the young wife who died before it was done.

The face you've seen on every poster and ticket — a young woman in strict profile, golden hair coiled and bound, in a gorgeous brocade and red gown, against a dark recess holding a few precise objects.

Portrait of Giovanna degli Albizzi Tornabuoni, painted 1489–90 by Domenico Ghirlandaio, the leading Florentine workshop master of his day — and, not incidentally, the man in whose workshop a teenage Michelangelo trained. Giovanna was a young Florentine noblewoman, married into the powerful Tornabuoni family.

And here is the heartbreak inside the beauty. By the time this portrait was finished, Giovanna was almost certainly already dead — she died in 1488, at around twenty, in childbirth. So this isn't a portrait of a living sitter; it's an act of memory and love, a husband's attempt to hold on to a face. Look at the Latin inscription on the cartellino behind her: it's a line adapted from the Roman poet Martial that says, in effect, "Art, if only you could also depict her character and soul, there would be no more beautiful painting on earth." Ghirlandaio is admitting the limit of his own art — he can give you the perfect surface of her, the hair and the jewels and the proud profile, but not the person who is gone. The objects in the niche — a prayer book, a brooch, a string of coral — speak of piety, virtue and protection. It's the museum's signature image, and once you know the story, that flawless profile becomes one of the most calmly moving things in the building. Downstairs lies Germany, and a very different intensity — this way to the next rooms.

TRACK 010 · 8–9 R-INTRO 168 WORDS · ~1 MIN

The German eye

WHERE YOU ARE

Rooms 8–9.

WHAT YOU SEE

Dürer, Cranach and Holbein — the German and Northern Renaissance.

LISTEN FOR

The sharp, precise, slightly unsettling way Northern painters looked at the world.

Step into the German rooms and the temperature changes. If the Italians were chasing grace and harmony, the German painters of the same years were after something sharper — intensity, detail, a slightly uncomfortable truthfulness, and a love of the strange.

This was the world of the Reformation, of Luther and religious upheaval, and you can feel the seriousness of it. Two giants dominate. Albrecht Dürer — the supreme genius of the German Renaissance, a man who travelled to Italy to learn its lessons and brought them home filtered through a northern obsession with detail. And Lucas Cranach the Elder — court painter, friend of Luther, and the inventor of a very particular kind of cool, knowing, slightly wicked elegance, especially in his nudes.

Between them they give you the two poles of German art: Dürer's piercing intellectual force, and Cranach's sly, courtly charm. Both are here at full power. Dürer first — and it's one of the strangest, most crowded faces-paintings you'll ever see, right this way.

TRACK 011 · 8 W-FOCUS 211 WORDS · ~2 MIN

Albrecht Dürer, *Jesus Among the Doctors*

WHERE YOU ARE

Room 8 — a ring of grotesque faces closing in on a calm boy.

WHAT YOU SEE

Albrecht Dürer, *Jesus Among the Doctors*, 1506 — oil on panel.

LISTEN FOR

The painting Dürer says he made in just five days — and the war of hands at its centre.

A claustrophobic, almost airless painting — a swarm of heads and grasping hands pressed tight to the surface, a calm young boy at the centre surrounded by grotesque old faces.

Jesus Among the Doctors, painted by Albrecht Dürer in 1506, while he was in Venice. It shows the boy Jesus, having slipped away from his parents, debating scripture with the learned elders in the Temple — and astonishing them. Dürer famously noted that he painted it in just five days, an almost boastful speed.

It's built on a brutal contrast. The boy is serene, smooth, luminous, his delicate fingers calmly counting off the points of his argument. Around him press the doctors — wrinkled, hook-nosed, gnarled, almost caricatures, their old hands tangling with his young ones at the very centre of the picture. Dürer crops in tight, with almost no background, so the heads crowd the surface and crowd you. He'd been studying Leonardo's grotesque-head drawings in Italy, and you can feel him testing them out — youth against age, clarity against confusion, faith against mere learning. It's unsettling on purpose. There's nowhere for your eye to rest except that calm young face. Beside this northern intensity hangs something far cooler and more seductive — Cranach, a little further on.

TRACK 012 · 8 W-FOCUS 198 WORDS · ~2 MIN

Lucas Cranach the Elder, *The Nymph at the Fountain*

WHERE YOU ARE

Room 8 — a nude reclining by a spring, an inscription above.

WHAT YOU SEE

Lucas Cranach the Elder, *The Nymph at the Fountain*, after 1537 — oil on panel.

LISTEN FOR

The warning the Latin verse gives you, and Cranach's sly, slippery idea of virtue.

A reclining nude — a nymph stretched out beside a spring, seemingly asleep, watched over by a couple of partridges and a quiet wooded landscape.

The Nymph at the Fountain, painted around 1530–34 by Lucas Cranach the Elder, court painter to the Electors of Saxony and one of the most productive, recognisable artists of the age. He painted versions of this reclining nymph more than once; she's a Renaissance invention dressed up as an antique legend.

There's usually an inscription with these — the nymph announces that she is the guardian of the sacred spring, and warns you not to disturb her sleep. But of course the whole painting is an invitation to look. Cranach's nudes are unmistakable: cool, pale, elongated, slightly artificial, often wearing nothing but a transparent veil and a piece of elaborate jewellery — eroticism with a knowing, courtly wink rather than Italian idealism. She's "asleep," but her eyes aren't quite closed. It's sophisticated, a little teasing, made for a worldly aristocratic patron who'd enjoy both the classical alibi and the frank sensuality underneath it. And the other German titan of the age painted the most powerful man in England — Holbein, through here.

TRACK 013 · 8–9 W-FOCUS 223 WORDS · ~2 MIN

Hans Holbein the Younger, *Portrait of Henry VIII of England*

WHERE YOU ARE

Rooms 8–9 — a small, dense portrait of England's most famous king.

WHAT YOU SEE

Hans Holbein the Younger, *Portrait of Henry VIII*, c. 1537 — oil on panel.

LISTEN FOR

How Holbein built the propaganda image of Henry VIII that we still picture today.

A small but commanding portrait — the unmistakable bulk of King Henry VIII, square-on, glittering with jewels and gold thread, filling the panel with sheer authority.

Portrait of Henry VIII of England, painted around 1537 by Hans Holbein the Younger, the German master who became court painter to the Tudor king. It is one of the most famous royal portraits ever made — the image through which the whole world still pictures Henry VIII.

This is propaganda of the highest order, and it works on you even now. Holbein squares the king's massive shoulders to the picture plane, loads him with cloth-of-gold, fur and gemstones rendered with hypnotic precision, and fixes him with a small, hard, frontal stare — so he seems to bear down on you with the full weight of absolute power. There's no flattery of charm here; the message is dominance, wealth, and an unanswerable will. Holbein was one of the supreme portraitists in history, able to make jewels and brocade gleam like the real thing while pinning a sitter's character in a single look. Versions and copies of this image spread across Europe and shaped Henry's fearsome reputation for centuries. To see the original, this close, is to feel the chill of Tudor power. Now from the cold English court to the warm light of Venice, just beyond.

TRACK 014 · 11 R-INTRO 171 WORDS · ~1 MIN

Venice: painting becomes colour

WHERE YOU ARE

Room 11.

WHAT YOU SEE

Titian and El Greco — the Venetian sixteenth century.

LISTEN FOR

How Venice swapped Florentine drawing for pure, smouldering colour and loose paint.

Now to Venice — and to a completely different idea of what a painting even *is*. In Florence, art was about *disegno*: drawing, line, design, the intellectual scaffolding underneath. In Venice, it was about *colore*: colour, light, atmosphere, paint itself laid on so you can feel the brush.

There's a reason. Venice was a city built on water and trade, soaked in shifting light and shimmering reflection, awash in luxurious imported pigments. Its painters — Titian above all, with Tintoretto and Bassano around him — learned to build a picture out of glowing colour and loaded brushwork rather than hard outline. They painted flesh that looks warm, fabric you want to touch, skies that breathe.

This Venetian revolution in colour is one of the great turning points in art; everyone downstream, from Rubens to the Impressionists, drinks from it. And in this same room hangs a young outsider who trained here before becoming the most singular painter in Spanish history — El Greco. Venice first, round the corner.

TRACK 015 · 11 W-FOCUS 216 WORDS · ~2 MIN

Titian, *The Penitent Saint Jerome*

WHERE YOU ARE

Room 11, the Venetian rooms — a saint in a dark wilderness.

WHAT YOU SEE

Titian, *The Penitent Saint Jerome*, c. 1575 — oil on canvas.

LISTEN FOR

How the late Titian almost abandons drawing for pure smouldering light and paint.

A dark, dramatic canvas — an old, half-naked hermit kneeling among rocks and shadow before a crucifix, his body lit against the wild gloom of the wilderness.

The Penitent Saint Jerome, painted around 1575 by Titian — Tiziano Vecellio — the towering master of Venetian painting, in the very last year of his long life. Jerome, the scholar-saint who translated the Bible, was often shown doing penance in the desert, beating his breast with a stone before the cross.

This is late Titian, and it's astonishing. Forget crisp outlines — up close the whole picture dissolves into smears, scrapes and dragged strokes of loaded paint, the saint's red robe almost flung onto the canvas, the rocks and foliage built from rough, broken touches. Step back and it all resolves into trembling light and shadow, flesh and stone and fading day. Titian had spent sixty years learning that paint itself — its colour, its very thickness — could carry emotion, and here, near death, he paints with total freedom, the surface as alive as the saint's anguish. He died of plague in Venice in 1576, the year after this. Painters from Rubens to the Impressionists would study exactly this loose, expressive late manner. The young Cretan who trained in this Venetian world is right beside it.

TRACK 016 · 11 W-FOCUS 211 WORDS · ~2 MIN

El Greco, *The Annunciation*

WHERE YOU ARE

Room 11 — an Annunciation lit by an unearthly, electric light.

WHAT YOU SEE

El Greco, *The Annunciation*, c. 1576 — oil on canvas.

LISTEN FOR

How a Cretan icon-painter turned Venetian colour into something visionary and strange.

An early, surprisingly Venetian-looking *Annunciation* — the angel Gabriel and the Virgin Mary, with that first flicker of the stretched, flickering style this painter would become famous for.

The Annunciation, painted around 1576 by El Greco — Doménikos Theotokópoulos, "the Greek." He was born in Crete, trained as an icon painter, came to Venice and Rome to absorb Titian and the Italians, and then moved to Toledo in Spain, where he became among the most extraordinary and unmistakable artists who ever lived.

This is a relatively early work, so you can still see the Venetian lessons fresh on him — the colour, the loaded brush, the Italian architecture. But watch the edges of his style starting to vibrate: the figures lengthening, the space tilting, the light turning strange and electric. Within a few years, in Toledo, he'd push all of this to its limit — bodies stretched like flames, acid colours, a swirling spiritual intensity that looked like nothing before and wouldn't be matched until the modern age, when painters rediscovered him with awe. Here you catch him at the hinge: the gifted student becoming the visionary. Down the timeline, a young man in Rome is about to blow European painting wide open — the Baroque, a short way on.

TRACK 017 · 12 R-INTRO 160 WORDS · ~1 MIN

The Baroque: a knock at the door

WHERE YOU ARE

Room 12.

WHAT YOU SEE

Caravaggio and the new drama of light and shadow.

LISTEN FOR

How one painter's hard light and real bodies kicked European art into a new age.

Cross into the seventeenth century and painting suddenly grabs you by the collar. This is the Baroque — the art of drama, of high contrast, of a moment caught at its most intense — and the man who lit the fuse was a violent, brilliant, short-lived Italian named Caravaggio.

His upheaval was simple and total. He painted directly from life, using ordinary people as his saints and sinners — dirty feet, real wrinkles, the works. And he plunged them into deep darkness, lit by a single raking shaft of light, so the holy moment seems to erupt out of the shadows of an ordinary room. It's theatre. It's a spotlight. It pulls you in close and won't let go.

Painters across Europe were stunned, and within a generation the whole continent was painting in this charged, shadowed, emotional new key — from Rubens's blazing energy to the quiet candlelight of the north. It starts with one dark canvas, over here.

TRACK 018 · 12 W-FOCUS 234 WORDS · ~2 MIN

Caravaggio, *Saint Catherine of Alexandria*

WHERE YOU ARE

Room 12 — a young saint half in shadow beside a great wheel.

WHAT YOU SEE

Caravaggio, *Saint Catherine of Alexandria*, c. 1598–99 — oil on canvas.

LISTEN FOR

The knock of real light and real flesh that changed European painting overnight.

A young woman kneeling in deep shadow, leaning on a great spiked wheel, a sword across her lap, lit by a hard diagonal light that picks her out of the surrounding dark.

Saint Catherine of Alexandria, painted around 1598–99 by Caravaggio — Michelangelo Merisi — one of the very few works by him in Spain and a star of this collection. Catherine was an early Christian martyr sentenced to be broken on a spiked wheel; when the wheel miraculously shattered, she was beheaded instead. So she leans on the broken wheel and holds the sword that killed her, with the martyr's palm beside her.

Everything that made Caravaggio revolutionary is here. The light is a hard spotlight from the upper left, modelling her out of near-total darkness — his famous *tenebrism*. The model is clearly a real woman, not an idealised type; you feel you could recognise her on the street. The textures are almost shockingly real — the gleam of the sword, the velvet, the cool skin. And there's psychological weight: she meets your gaze directly, calm and grave, an ordinary young woman who has accepted an extraordinary fate. Caravaggio lived fast and dangerously — brawls, a killing, flight, an early death — and you can feel that raw intensity pressed into the paint. From his shadows, the Baroque exploded outward; one of its greatest engines, Rubens, is right along here.

TRACK 019 · 13–15 W-FOCUS 204 WORDS · ~2 MIN

Peter Paul Rubens, *Venus and Cupid*

WHERE YOU ARE

Rooms 13–15 — a mirror, a goddess, and a glow of warm flesh.

WHAT YOU SEE

Peter Paul Rubens, *Venus and Cupid*, c. 1606–11 — oil on canvas.

LISTEN FOR

How Rubens uses a mirror to pull you into the picture — and make you complicit.

A warm, sensuous painting of the goddess Venus seen from behind, gazing at herself in a mirror held by Cupid, her golden hair and luminous skin filling the canvas.

Venus and Cupid, painted around 1606–11 by Peter Paul Rubens, the Flemish master who was the most successful and influential painter in all of seventeenth-century Europe — and a diplomat and scholar besides. Here Venus, goddess of love and beauty, admires her reflection while her son Cupid holds the mirror.

It's a clever device: the mirror shows us her face while we see her back, so we get all of her at once — and it calmly makes *us* the ones doing the looking, caught in the act of admiring beauty admiring itself. But mostly, feel the sheer life in it. Rubens learned from Titian's Venetian colour and Caravaggio's drama and fused them into something overflowing — warm, fleshy, glowing, abundant. His figures always seem to brim with health and energy and appetite for the world. He ran a huge, busy workshop and painted everything from altarpieces to royal commissions, but the signature is always that pulse of vitality. And Spain answered the Baroque in its own grave key — Zurbarán, not far on.

TRACK 020 · 13–15 W-FOCUS 212 WORDS · ~2 MIN

Francisco de Zurbarán, *Saint Casilda*

WHERE YOU ARE

Rooms 13–15 — a richly dressed woman carrying roses in her skirt.

WHAT YOU SEE

Francisco de Zurbarán, *Saint Casilda*, c. 1630–35 — oil on canvas.

LISTEN FOR

The miracle of the roses, and why a Spanish saint is dressed like a court lady.

A striking full-length young woman in a gorgeous, jewel-embroidered gown, carrying roses in the folds of her skirt, set against a plain dark ground.

Saint Casilda, painted around 1630–35 by Francisco de Zurbarán, one of the great masters of the Spanish Golden Age — the same seventeenth-century Spain as Velázquez and Murillo. These rooms hold Spain's contribution to the Baroque, and nearby hangs a tender *Virgin and Child with Saint Rose of Viterbo* by Bartolomé Esteban Murillo.

Casilda was, by legend, the daughter of a Muslim king of Toledo who secretly carried food to Christian prisoners against her father's will. Caught one day with her skirt full of bread, she was saved by a miracle — the bread turned to roses, which is why she carries flowers here. But notice what Zurbarán really cares about: the *fabric*. He renders her embroidered silk and jewels with an almost hypnotic, sculptural solidity, the figure lit by a strong, raking light against deep shadow — Caravaggio's drama brought to Spanish soil. Zurbarán painted whole series of these single, monumental female saints, richly dressed and serene, and shipped many to the churches of Spanish America. Quiet, grand, and unmistakably Spanish. Now to the cool Protestant north — the Dutch — a few steps on.

TRACK 021 · 23–28 R-INTRO 186 WORDS · ~1 MIN

Holland: a republic of ordinary things

WHERE YOU ARE

Rooms 23–28.

WHAT YOU SEE

Rembrandt, Hals, Saenredam and the Dutch Golden Age.

LISTEN FOR

Why a small Protestant republic started painting itself — faces, churches, weather, things.

Something genuinely new happens in these Dutch rooms, and it's worth pausing to feel why. The seventeenth-century Dutch Republic was unlike anywhere else in Europe: Protestant, so no grand church commissions; a republic, so no royal court; and prosperous, thanks to trade and a confident middle class. So who bought paintings? Ordinary citizens — merchants, brewers, shopkeepers — for their own homes.

And that changed *what* got painted. Instead of saints and kings, Dutch artists painted the world these buyers lived in: their own faces, their families, their flat green landscapes under enormous skies, their tidy interiors, the gleam of a lemon on a laid table. Painting came down out of heaven and the palace and settled into the living room.

It produced some of the most quietly perfect art ever made — and one outright genius, Rembrandt, who took this ordinary world and found in it the full depth of the human soul. Watch how much feeling these painters wring from the everyday: a face, a sky, a swept church floor. Rembrandt first — looking at himself, as he did all his life, close by.

TRACK 022 · 27 W-FOCUS 220 WORDS · ~2 MIN

Rembrandt, *Self-portrait wearing a hat and two Chains*

WHERE YOU ARE

Room 27 — a self-portrait, hat shadowing the eyes.

WHAT YOU SEE

Rembrandt, *Self-portrait wearing a Hat and Two Chains*, c. 1642–43 — oil on panel.

LISTEN FOR

What Rembrandt is doing watching himself — and the gold chains that aren't quite what they seem.

A portrait of the artist himself — a solid, middle-aged man in a dark hat, gold chains across his chest, emerging from a warm brown gloom, looking steadily out.

A *Self-portrait* by Rembrandt van Rijn, from around 1642–43 — one of roughly eighty self-portraits he made across his life, more than almost any artist before him. Here he's at the height of his Amsterdam success, prosperous and confident, the gold chains a sign of honour and status.

Nobody has ever looked at themselves the way Rembrandt did — not out of vanity, but as a lifelong experiment in what a face can hold. He used himself as the model always available, free, and infinitely patient, and across the decades the self-portraits become a single, unflinching autobiography in paint: the cocky young man, the successful master you see here, and later the bankrupt, grieving old man who painted himself with merciless honesty and overwhelming compassion. Look at how the light finds his face out of the shadow, and how loosely, almost roughly, the paint is handled up close — and yet how completely *alive* he is. He's not performing for you. He's studying himself, and letting you watch. Beside him, a master of the lighter touch caught a whole family in the open air — Frans Hals, a little way on.

TRACK 023 · 27 W-FOCUS 190 WORDS · ~2 MIN

Frans Hals, *Family Group in a Landscape*

WHERE YOU ARE

Room 27 — a whole family arranged easily in a landscape.

WHAT YOU SEE

Frans Hals, *Family Group in a Landscape*, c. 1645–48 — oil on canvas.

LISTEN FOR

How Hals catches living, breathing people mid-movement, against the stiffness of the age.

A relaxed, informal group — a family arranged outdoors in a landscape, the figures turning to one another with an easy, almost snapshot naturalness.

Family Group in a Landscape, painted 1645–48 by Frans Hals, the great portraitist of Haarlem and the supreme master of the *lively* likeness. Group portraits were a Dutch speciality — families and civic guilds clubbing together to be painted — and Hals made them feel less posed than anyone.

The magic is in the brushwork. Step close and the lace collars, the hands, the smiling faces dissolve into quick, slashing, almost careless-looking strokes — and then step back and everything snaps into crackling life. Hals worked fast and loose, leaving the energy of the brush right there on the surface, centuries before the Impressionists made that a movement. He's after the fleeting, animated moment — a turn of the head, the beginning of a smile, a child squirming — rather than stiff formal dignity. You can feel the warmth between these people. It's one of the friendliest paintings in the museum. Now from people to pure, swept, silent space — Saenredam's church, just along here.

TRACK 024 · 23 W-FOCUS 177 WORDS · ~1 MIN

Pieter Saenredam, *The West Façade of the Church of Saint Mary in Utrecht*

WHERE YOU ARE

Room 23 — the pale, severe front of a stripped Dutch church.

WHAT YOU SEE

Pieter Saenredam, *The West Façade of Saint Mary in Utrecht*, 1662 — oil on panel.

LISTEN FOR

Why an empty whitewashed church became a subject — and the Protestant world behind it.

A precise, pale, almost empty painting of a church — clean architecture, soft light, a great calm hush hanging over the whole thing.

The West Façade of the Church of Saint Mary in Utrecht, painted in 1662 by Pieter Jansz. Saenredam, the painter who made a whole career out of one subject: the interiors and exteriors of Dutch churches, rendered with almost scientific accuracy.

These Protestant churches had been stripped — the Reformation cleared out the statues, the gold, the painted altarpieces — and Saenredam saw the strange new beauty in that emptiness: bare whitewashed stone, clear glass, pure architectural geometry, flooded with soft northern daylight. He worked from careful on-site drawings and measurements, almost like an architect, then composed paintings of extraordinary serenity. There are no dramatic events here, often barely any people — just light, space, stone and silence. It's a kind of devotion all its own: holiness found not in spectacle but in clarity and quiet. After the hush of the church, step out under the huge Dutch sky — landscape, just ahead.

TRACK 025 · 26–28 W-FOCUS 195 WORDS · ~2 MIN

Dutch landscape

WHERE YOU ARE

Rooms 26–28 — wide skies and low Dutch horizons.

WHAT YOU SEE

Seventeenth-century Dutch landscape — van Goyen, Ruisdael and their circle.

LISTEN FOR

How the new Dutch Republic learned to take pride in plain weather, flat land and big sky.

The landscape rooms — low horizons, vast cloudy skies taking up most of the canvas, flat green country, a windmill or a river, weather rolling through.

The great Dutch landscape tradition — masters like Jacob van Ruisdael, Jan van Goyen and Salomon van Ruysdael, who turned the unremarkable flatness of their own country into one of the glories of European painting.

Notice the proportion: the land is squeezed down to a thin strip along the bottom, and the sky — restless, luminous, full of moving cloud — swells to fill two-thirds or more of the picture. That's the truth of Holland, a low country under an enormous, ever-changing sky, much of it reclaimed from the sea. There are no mountains, no drama of terrain; the drama is all in the light and weather. These painters invented landscape as a subject worthy of serious art entirely on its own, with no myth or story propping it up — just this place, this light, this passing moment of cloud. Two centuries later the Impressionists would call that revolutionary. The Dutch did it calmly, first. Now the world tips into the elegant eighteenth century, a little further on.

TRACK 026 · 16–24 R-INTRO 181 WORDS · ~1 MIN

The Grand Tour: elegance and the view

WHERE YOU ARE

Rooms 16–24.

WHAT YOU SEE

Canaletto, Fragonard and Gainsborough — the eighteenth century.

LISTEN FOR

The age of travel, souvenirs and flattery — view-paintings and silken portraits.

The eighteenth century is the age of elegance, wit and travel — and these rooms have a lighter, brighter air than the heavy Baroque you've just left.

Two things drive the painting here. One is the Grand Tour: the fashion among wealthy young Europeans, the British especially, for a long educational journey through Italy. They wanted souvenirs — and so a whole industry of dazzling city "view paintings" grew up, above all in Venice, where Canaletto turned the city itself into the ultimate luxury postcard. The other is the Rococo: a French style of feathery lightness, pastel colour, flirtation and pleasure, made for aristocratic salons where life was a charming game.

And alongside the frothy French scenes, you'll find the cool confidence of British portraiture — Gainsborough, Reynolds and their rivals, painting the landed gentry with easy grandeur. It's a century that prized charm, refinement and surface delight — right up until, at the very end, revolution and a darker genius named Goya blow the whole pretty world apart. Venice first, the most beautiful view in the building, right this way.

TRACK 027 · 16–22 W-FOCUS 198 WORDS · ~2 MIN

Canaletto, *The Grand Canal from San Vio, Venice*

WHERE YOU ARE

Rooms 16–22 — a crisp, sunlit view down the Grand Canal.

WHAT YOU SEE

Canaletto, *The Grand Canal from San Vio, Venice*, c. 1723–24 — oil on canvas.

LISTEN FOR

The eighteenth-century souvenir trade, and the optical trick behind Canaletto's precision.

A crystalline view of Venice — the Grand Canal opening out under a wide blue sky, palaces lining the water, gondolas and working boats catching the light.

The Grand Canal from San Vio, Venice, painted around 1723–24 by Canaletto — Giovanni Antonio Canal — the supreme master of the *veduta*, the topographical city view. He painted Venice so precisely and so seductively that his works became the must-have souvenir for British aristocrats on the Grand Tour.

Look at the light and the air. Canaletto renders the buildings with near-architectural exactness — you could almost navigate by this painting — but he bathes everything in a clear, sparkling Venetian atmosphere that makes the whole city shimmer. He used optical aids, possibly a camera obscura, to get the perspective crisp, and he often adjusted reality a little, nudging buildings for a better composition. The result is Venice as you wish it always looked: luminous, orderly, eternal. These views shaped how the whole world has pictured Venice ever since — every postcard of the place is downstream of Canaletto. Hold this brightness in mind, because the next stop trades it for French perfume and flirtation — Fragonard, through here.

TRACK 028 · 24 W-FOCUS 195 WORDS · ~2 MIN

Jean-Honoré Fragonard, *The See-Saw*

WHERE YOU ARE

Room 24 — a girl on a see-saw in a frothy garden.

WHAT YOU SEE

Jean-Honoré Fragonard, *The See-Saw*, c. 1750–52 — oil on canvas.

LISTEN FOR

The flirtation and lightness of Rococo France — just before the world cracks open.

A frothy, sunlit garden scene — young people at play on a see-saw among feathery trees, all pastel silks and dappled light.

The See-Saw, painted around 1750–52 by the young Jean-Honoré Fragonard, one of the great talents of the French Rococo — the style of Watteau and Boucher before him, all lightness, leisure and gentle eroticism.

This is painting as pure pleasure. The subject is essentially nothing — privileged young people amusing themselves in a lush garden — and that's the point. The Rococo was the art of an aristocracy with time on its hands, and it celebrates flirtation, play, and the delicious surfaces of life: shimmering silk, warm skin, leaves trembling in soft light. Fragonard's brush is quick and sensuous; the whole thing feels improvised and alive, like a stolen afternoon. There's often a sly undercurrent of romance and innuendo in his work — a see-saw, after all, is all about who goes up as the other comes down. Within a generation, the French upheaval would sweep this gilded world away and brand its art as decadent. Catch it here at its most carefree. Now Britain, painting itself with cool grandeur, just beyond.

TRACK 029 · 24 W-FOCUS 207 WORDS · ~2 MIN

Thomas Gainsborough, *Portrait of Sarah Buxton*

WHERE YOU ARE

Room 24 — an elegant young Englishwoman, feathery brushwork.

WHAT YOU SEE

Thomas Gainsborough, *Portrait of Sarah Buxton*, c. 1776–77 — oil on canvas.

LISTEN FOR

How Gainsborough flatters his sitter while painting the silk and air with pure speed.

An elegant English portrait — a young woman, fashionably dressed, set with easy grace against a soft, feathery landscape painted in silvery, flickering strokes.

Portrait of Sarah Buxton, by Thomas Gainsborough, who with his rival Sir Joshua Reynolds dominated eighteenth-century British portraiture. This panel hung for years at Daylesford House, the English home of the Baron and Baroness Thyssen, before joining the collection.

Gainsborough is the one to watch. He always insisted that portraits were merely his trade and landscape his real love — and you can feel it here, in how the sitter melts into a shimmering, half-invented parkland behind her, the boundary between figure and setting deliberately soft. Look at the handling of the silk and lace: up close it's almost abstract, a flurry of quick, feathery touches, yet from a step back it reads as the most refined fabric imaginable. His early landscapes drank from the Dutch masters you saw upstairs; his portraits married that love of nature to the faces of the British gentry. The result defined an image of that confident, landed class — at ease, gracious, entirely sure of its place in the world. And then, in the very next room, all that politeness shatters — Goya, round the corner.

TRACK 030 · 29 R-INTRO 170 WORDS · ~1 MIN

1800: the world cracks open

WHERE YOU ARE

Room 29.

WHAT YOU SEE

Goya and Caspar David Friedrich — the threshold of the modern.

LISTEN FOR

How two very different painters drag art across the line into the modern world.

You've reached the end of Level 2, and the end of the old world. Around 1800 everything changes — revolutions, Napoleon, the collapse of the old certainties — and painting changes with it. The age of elegant surfaces gives way to something turbulent, emotional, and recognisably modern.

Two figures here mark the threshold. Francisco de Goya — court painter turned bitter witness, who started in the Rococo world and ended up painting nightmares, war and human cruelty with a raw modern honesty that makes him feel like our contemporary. And the German Caspar David Friedrich, the foremost painter of Romanticism, who turned landscape into a mirror of the soul — lonely figures before infinite skies, mountains and seas, the vast and the sublime.

Between them, the door to the modern age swings open: the self, the unconscious, doubt, awe, terror. When you walk downstairs, you'll walk straight into the nineteenth and twentieth centuries that grew from this rupture. Goya and Friedrich, a short way on — then down we go.

TRACK 031 · 29 W-FOCUS 210 WORDS · ~2 MIN

Francisco de Goya, *Tío Paquete*

WHERE YOU ARE

Room 29 — a blind beggar's head looming out of the dark.

WHAT YOU SEE

Francisco de Goya, *Tío Paquete*, c. 1819–20 — oil on canvas.

LISTEN FOR

The Madrid street figure Goya paints with terrifying, modern honesty.

A small, dark, unsettling portrait — the head and shoulders of an old blind man, his eye-sockets sunken and sightless, his mouth twisted into something between a grin and a grimace.

Tío Paquete — "Uncle Paquete" — painted around 1819–20 by Francisco de Goya, the towering Spanish master who bridges the old world and the modern one. Paquete was a real man, a blind beggar well known to Madrileños, who sat on the steps of the church of San Felipe el Real and sang and played the guitar for coins.

This was painted at the same time as Goya's terrifying Black Paintings, and you can feel that same fearless, unflinching gaze. There's no flattery, no idealising — but there's no cruelty either. Goya, deaf himself by now and disillusioned with the world, looks straight at this poor blind man and finds something raw and human and oddly tender in him. The thick, slashing brushwork and the way the face surges out of the brown darkness make it feel startlingly modern — more like something from a century later. Goya is the hinge of this whole museum: behind him, the old masters; ahead of him, the modern age he helped to birth. His Romantic counterpart from the north is over here.

TRACK 032 · 29 W-FOCUS 208 WORDS · ~2 MIN

Caspar David Friedrich, *Easter Morning*

WHERE YOU ARE

Room 29 — three women on a path under a pale dawn sky.

WHAT YOU SEE

Caspar David Friedrich, *Easter Morning*, c. 1828–35 — oil on canvas.

LISTEN FOR

How Friedrich loads an empty landscape with the whole weight of death and resurrection.

A still, solemn landscape — three small figures on a winding path between bare, leafless trees, under a pale dawn sky, the whole scene hushed and luminous.

Easter Morning by Caspar David Friedrich, the greatest painter of German Romanticism. The Thyssen's holding of his work is precious — Friedrich is rare outside Germany — and this small canvas distils everything that makes him extraordinary.

With Friedrich, nothing is just scenery; every element carries meaning. Read this one slowly. The bare trees and the season — late winter giving way to spring — speak of death and rebirth. The moon still hanging in the sky stands for the passing world and the hope of eternal life; the breaking dawn is the Resurrection itself, which is why it's *Easter* morning. The three small women walking the path become every soul making its way toward the light. Friedrich fills the canvas with quiet emptiness and sets tiny human figures against the vast, so that you, too, feel small before something infinite. After the noise of revolution and war, he offers silence, awe, and the individual soul alone before the universe — one of the deepest roots of modern art. Now — down the stairs, into the modern world, right along here.

TRACK 033 · 30–32 R-INTRO 183 WORDS · ~1 MIN

Down a floor, across an ocean: America

WHERE YOU ARE

Rooms 30–32 — one floor down.

WHAT YOU SEE

The Hudson River School and John Singer Sargent.

LISTEN FOR

How American art found its own subject — first the wilderness, then high society.

You've come down one floor and forward about a hundred years — and the first thing the museum does on this level is spring a genuine surprise: America.

This is one of the Thyssen's best-kept secrets. It holds one of the finest collections of nineteenth-century American painting anywhere outside the United States — a whole story most European museums skip entirely. The younger Baron, Hans Heinrich, fell in love with American art when almost no one else in Europe collected it, and these rooms are the reward.

What you'll see is a young nation painting itself into existence. Vast, untouched wilderness — mountains, forests, waterfalls — painted as a kind of national scripture, proof of America's God-given grandeur. Then the cities, the light on the water, the new urban life. It's landscape doing the work of identity: *this is who we are*. Watch for the sheer scale and optimism of it, so different from the older, more crowded European world upstairs. Then, through here, we cross back to France for the revolution everyone knows by name — Impressionism. America first, just beyond.

TRACK 034 · 31 W-FOCUS 205 WORDS · ~2 MIN

The American sublime: Cole, Church and the Hudson River School

WHERE YOU ARE

Room 31 — vast, luminous American wilderness.

WHAT YOU SEE

The Hudson River School — Thomas Cole, Frederic Church and their circle.

LISTEN FOR

How a young nation painted its own landscape as a kind of scripture.

Big, luminous landscapes — dramatic American wilderness, glowing skies, mountains and rivers stretching toward a radiant horizon.

Paintings of the Hudson River School, America's first homegrown art movement, led by Thomas Cole and his brilliant pupil Frederic Edwin Church, working from the 1820s through mid-century.

To a young United States, the wilderness *was* the national identity. Europe had cathedrals and ruins and centuries of history; America had something it decided was even greater — untouched nature on a colossal scale, seemingly given by God. So these painters made landscape into a kind of patriotic scripture: glowing, awe-struck, enormous, every sunset and mountain range charged with destiny and moral meaning. Church in particular would draw crowds who paid admission to see a single giant canvas, as if it were a movie. But look closer and there's often a shadow too — a blasted tree, a sign of settlement encroaching — an early, uneasy awareness that this paradise was already being lost to the axe and the railroad. It's the American dream and its doubts, painted in light. Few European museums tell this story at all; the Thyssen tells it beautifully. From the wild continent to high society, a great American abroad — Sargent, round the corner.

TRACK 035 · 32 W-FOCUS 189 WORDS · ~2 MIN

John Singer Sargent, *Portrait of Millicent, Duchess of Sutherland*

WHERE YOU ARE

Room 32 — a society duchess in shimmering paint.

WHAT YOU SEE

John Singer Sargent, *Portrait of Millicent, Duchess of Sutherland*, 1904 — oil on canvas.

LISTEN FOR

The dazzle and the unease in Sargent's portraits of the very rich.

A glamorous full-length society portrait — an elegant woman in flowing dress, painted with dazzling, confident, almost liquid brushwork.

Portrait of Millicent, Duchess of Sutherland, painted in 1904 by John Singer Sargent, the American expatriate who became the most sought-after portraitist in the English-speaking world.

Sargent could make paint *perform*. Look at the bravura of it — the satin, the skin, the sheer presence of the sitter conjured with strokes that look effortless and are anything but. He painted the Anglo-American aristocracy and plutocracy of the Gilded Age at the height of their confidence, and he flattered them, yes, but he also caught character: intelligence, hauteur, a flicker of the real person under the role. Millicent, Duchess of Sutherland, was a famous beauty, society hostess and social reformer, and Sargent gives her every inch of glamour while keeping her alive and particular. He learned his fluid touch from Velázquez and Hals — you've just seen Hals upstairs — proof of how the whole story connects. After this last glow of grand portraiture, painting is about to be turned upside down in Paris. Impressionism, a short way on.

TRACK 036 · 33 R-INTRO 172 WORDS · ~1 MIN

Paris, 1874: the light moves

WHERE YOU ARE

Room 33 — the Impressionist rooms.

WHAT YOU SEE

Manet, Degas, Monet, Morisot, Cassatt, Van Gogh and Cézanne.

LISTEN FOR

The single richest room in the museum, and the revolution in how light got painted.

Now to the upheaval whose name everyone knows. In Paris in the 1870s, a group of young painters got tired of the brown, polished, studio-bound art the official Salon demanded — grand historical scenes finished to a glassy shine. They wanted to paint what the eye actually sees: light, the fleeting moment, modern life as it happens.

So they did something radical. They went outdoors, painting directly in front of the subject. They used quick, broken, visible strokes of pure colour to catch the shimmer of sunlight, water, weather. They painted not noble myths but ordinary modern things — a train station, a dancer, a boating party, a woman on horseback in the park. Critics mocked them; one sneered at a Monet titled *Impression, Sunrise*, and the insult — "Impressionists" — stuck.

It's hard now to feel how shocking this was, because they won so completely that their way of seeing became *our* way of seeing. Manet, Monet, Degas, Morisot — the room is full of them. Manet first, over here.

TRACK 037 · 33 W-FOCUS 188 WORDS · ~2 MIN

Édouard Manet, *Horsewoman, Full-Face (L'Amazone)*

WHERE YOU ARE

Room 33, the Impressionist rooms — a woman on horseback facing you.

WHAT YOU SEE

Édouard Manet, *Horsewoman, Full-Face (L'Amazone)*, c. 1882 — oil on canvas.

LISTEN FOR

The unfinished late Manet, and how modern that bare, frank handling still looks.

A striking, loosely painted portrait of a woman in dark riding habit — *l'amazone*, a horsewoman — facing you directly, fresh and unfinished-looking.

Horsewoman, Full-Face (L'Amazone), painted around 1882 by Édouard Manet — the older painter the Impressionists revered as their leader, the man who'd kicked open the door for all of them.

Manet was the great bridge. He came out of the Old Master tradition — he loved Velázquez and Hals — but he stripped away their finish and their storytelling, painting modern people in flat, bold, startlingly direct strokes that scandalised the official art world. This is one of his last works, painted as he was dying, young, of a wasting illness; it has the freshness of a sketch, the paint laid on quick and alive. The woman looks straight out at you with cool self-possession — a modern, urban, independent figure, exactly the contemporary life Manet insisted was worthy of serious art. Notice how "unfinished" it feels compared with everything upstairs; that openness, that visible speed, is the modern sensibility being born. Beside him, the master of movement — Degas, right along here.

TRACK 038 · 33 W-FOCUS 202 WORDS · ~2 MIN

Edgar Degas, *Swaying Dancer (Dancer in Green)*

WHERE YOU ARE

Room 33 — a single dancer caught off-balance in green.

WHAT YOU SEE

Edgar Degas, *Swaying Dancer (Dancer in Green)*, 1877–79 — pastel.

LISTEN FOR

How Degas turns the ballet into something seen by accident, from a strange angle.

A vivid pastel of ballet dancers — one tipping forward in a swirl of green skirts, the viewpoint high and oblique, as if you're looking down from a theatre box.

Swaying Dancer (Dancer in Green), made 1877–79 by Edgar Degas, the Impressionist who was obsessed, above all, with the human body in motion — and especially with dancers.

Degas insisted he wasn't really an Impressionist — he disliked painting outdoors and cared more about drawing than most of the group. But he shared their hunger for the modern, fleeting moment, and nobody caught movement like he did. Look at the radical composition: the steep downward angle, the dancers cut off by the frame's edge, the asymmetry — he learned this from photography and from Japanese prints, both new and exciting in Paris then. It feels snatched, off-balance, *now*. And notice the medium — pastel, which let him work fast and build up shimmering, broken layers of colour, perfect for the gauzy tutus and stage light. Behind the prettiness there's a cool, almost clinical eye: these are working dancers, exhausted, mid-effort, observed rather than romanticised. From the stage to the open air — Monet and the landscape painters, not far on.

TRACK 039 · 33 W-FOCUS 228 WORDS · ~2 MIN

Claude Monet, *Charing Cross Bridge*

WHERE YOU ARE

Room 33 — a London bridge dissolving in fog and light.

WHAT YOU SEE

Claude Monet, *Charing Cross Bridge*, 1899–1904 — oil on canvas.

LISTEN FOR

How Monet paints not the bridge but the London air itself, thick with smoke and sun.

A misty, almost dissolving view of a London bridge over the Thames — the structure barely there, swallowed in coloured fog, with the faint ghost of a train and the river shimmering beneath.

Charing Cross Bridge, painted in 1903 by Claude Monet, the purest and most committed of the Impressionists. It belongs to a famous series he made of the Thames in London, returning again and again to the same bridges to catch the city's celebrated fog at different moments.

This is Monet's whole philosophy in one canvas. His real subject was never the bridge — it was the *light and atmosphere* wrapped around it, which of course never stop changing. So he worked fast, layering small touches of lilac, rose, blue and gold to capture the London mist swallowing the iron and smoke of the modern city. Stand close and it's almost pure abstraction, a haze of broken colour with hardly an edge to be found; step back and your own eye assembles it into water, fog, and fading light. He began these on the spot in London and finished many back home in his garden at Giverny, chasing the memory of the haze. It looks effortless and dreamlike — and it changed forever how the world sees light. Two women helped invent all this and are too often left out — a few steps on.

TRACK 040 · 33 W-FOCUS 202 WORDS · ~2 MIN

Berthe Morisot and Mary Cassatt

WHERE YOU ARE

Room 33 — intimate scenes of women and children.

WHAT YOU SEE

Berthe Morisot and Mary Cassatt, the women of Impressionism.

LISTEN FOR

What the two great women Impressionists could paint that their male colleagues couldn't reach.

Intimate, light-filled scenes — a woman, a child, a quiet domestic moment — painted with the same broken Impressionist brightness but a distinctly tender, inward eye.

Paintings by Berthe Morisot and Mary Cassatt, the two outstanding women at the heart of Impressionism — Morisot French and central to the original group, Cassatt an American who joined them in Paris.

They were full members of the movement, not followers — Morisot exhibited in almost every Impressionist show and was as radical a brush as any of the men. But their subject matter was shaped by what society allowed women to access: not the cafés, bars and backstage worlds the men painted, but the domestic sphere — mothers and children, women reading, dressing, taking tea, lost in thought. Far from a limitation, they turned it into a strength, bringing a closeness and psychological tenderness to these private moments that the men rarely matched. Morisot's brushwork is famously free and feathery; Cassatt's mother-and-child scenes have a frank, unsentimental warmth. They're a reminder that the story of modern art has always had more authors than the famous list admits. Now two painters who pushed past Impressionism into something stranger — Van Gogh and Cézanne, close by.

TRACK 041 · 33 W-FOCUS 217 WORDS · ~2 MIN

Vincent van Gogh, *Les Vessenots in Auvers*

WHERE YOU ARE

Room 33 — a cluster of farm cottages under a churning sky.

WHAT YOU SEE

Vincent van Gogh, *Les Vessenots in Auvers*, 1890 — oil on canvas.

LISTEN FOR

A painting from the last weeks of Van Gogh's life, and the energy crackling through every stroke.

A landscape that vibrates — fields and a few houses near a village, the whole surface alive with thick, rhythmic, swirling strokes of intense colour.

Les Vessenots in Auvers, painted by Vincent van Gogh in 1890 — in the last months of his life, at Auvers-sur-Oise outside Paris, where he died that July at thirty-seven.

This is the heart of Post-Impressionism — the generation that took the Impressionists' bright colour but wanted more than a fleeting visual impression; they wanted feeling, structure, meaning. With van Gogh, the feeling is everything. Look at the brushwork: every stroke is separate, urgent, directional, the paint squeezed on thick, so the field seems to ripple and the whole landscape pulses with a nervous, ecstatic energy. He's not just recording Auvers; he's pouring his own turbulent inner life into it. Van Gogh sold almost nothing in his lifetime and battled terrible mental illness, painting with furious speed in his final years — this canvas comes from that last desperate, miraculous burst. Within decades he'd be one of the most beloved artists on earth, the patron saint of the suffering, sincere artist. Stand close to feel the hand that made it. Beside him, the other great father of modern art took the opposite path — toward order — Cézanne, right this way.

TRACK 042 · 33 W-FOCUS 238 WORDS · ~2 MIN

Paul Cézanne, *Seated Man*

WHERE YOU ARE

Room 33 — a seated man built from blocks of colour.

WHAT YOU SEE

Paul Cézanne, *Seated Man*, 1905–06 — oil on canvas.

LISTEN FOR

How Cézanne takes painting apart and rebuilds it from facets of colour — the bridge to everything modern.

A solid, weighty portrait of a man sitting calmly, built from patient, blocky planes of colour — quiet, monumental, faintly unfinished at the edges.

Seated Man, painted around 1905–06 by Paul Cézanne — one of his very last works, made in the final year of his life — by the painter Picasso and Matisse both called "the father of us all," the man who turned Impressionism into the doorway to the twentieth century.

Where Van Gogh poured in emotion, Cézanne went looking for structure. He admired the Impressionists' colour but found their work too fleeting — he wanted, he said, "to make of Impressionism something solid and durable, like the art of the museums." So he rebuilt the visible world out of small, deliberate planes of colour, faceting a face or a body into a calmly geometric architecture, often hinting at several viewpoints at once. Look how the man sits with the gravity of a mountain, assembled patch by patch, the paint thinning to bare canvas at the margins because Cézanne would rather leave a passage unresolved than fake it. It looks calm, even awkward — and it's revolutionary, loosening painting from the single fixed viewpoint that had ruled since the Renaissance. A few years after his death, two young men named Picasso and Braque stared hard at exactly this and invented Cubism. First, the explosion of colour and feeling next door — a little way on.

TRACK 043 · 34–35 R-INTRO 181 WORDS · ~1 MIN

Germany screams in colour: Expressionism

WHERE YOU ARE

Rooms 34–35.

WHAT YOU SEE

Kirchner, Otto Dix, Franz Marc and the German Expressionists.

LISTEN FOR

How German painters used violent colour and distortion to paint feeling, not fact.

Now the twentieth century arrives in earnest, and it arrives loud. These rooms hold one of the Thyssen's great strengths — German Expressionism — and after the French delicacy next door, the change of voltage is electric.

The Expressionists weren't interested in how the world *looks*; they wanted to paint how it *feels* — anxiety, desire, alienation, raw emotion — and they did it with violent, unnatural colour and harsh, jagged forms. Two groups led the charge. *Die Brücke* — "the Bridge" — young firebrands in Dresden, all clashing colour and angular bodies, electric and uneasy. And *Der Blaue Reiter* — "the Blue Rider" — in Munich, more lyrical and spiritual, pushing colour toward pure feeling and, soon, toward abstraction.

This was art made in a Germany sliding toward catastrophe — the First World War, then the chaos that followed — and the unease is right there on the surface. The Nazis would later brand it "degenerate" and try to destroy it. Feel the nervous energy in these rooms; it's the modern psyche cracking open. Kirchner first, just along here.

TRACK 044 · 35 W-FOCUS 211 WORDS · ~2 MIN

Ernst Ludwig Kirchner, *Fränzi in front of a Carved Chair*

WHERE YOU ARE

Room 35, the Expressionist rooms — a girl in jagged, acid colour.

WHAT YOU SEE

Ernst Ludwig Kirchner, *Fränzi in front of a Carved Chair*, 1910 — oil on canvas.

LISTEN FOR

The raw, deliberately crude energy of the Brücke group, and the child model at its centre.

A jarring, vivid portrait of a young girl — acid greens and oranges, a mask-like face, a strange carved figure looming on the chair beside her.

Fränzi in front of a Carved Chair, painted around 1910 by Ernst Ludwig Kirchner, the driving force of Die Brücke. Fränzi was a young girl who modelled for the group in their Dresden studio, a freewheeling bohemian world the artists treated as a revolt against stiff bourgeois Germany.

Look at the colour — it's deliberately *wrong*. Her face is greenish, the background hot orange, the whole thing clashing and raw, because Kirchner isn't describing how the girl looked but firing the emotional charge of the encounter straight at you. The brushwork is fast and rough; the carved figure on the chair, borrowed from the African and Oceanic art the group admired, adds a note of the primal and uncanny. There's something both tender and unsettling here, a nervous intensity that runs through all of Die Brücke. Within a few years the First World War would shatter this little utopia — Kirchner had a breakdown in the army and never fully recovered. The raw nerve of it is the whole point. A colder, sharper kind of portrait hangs nearby — Otto Dix, just ahead.

TRACK 045 · 35 W-FOCUS 217 WORDS · ~2 MIN

Otto Dix, *Hugo Erfurth with Dog*

WHERE YOU ARE

Room 35 — a sharp-edged portrait of a man and his dog.

WHAT YOU SEE

Otto Dix, *Hugo Erfurth with Dog*, 1926 — tempera and oil on panel.

LISTEN FOR

The cold, surgical precision of New Objectivity, and the photographer who sat for it.

A coolly precise portrait of a seated man in a dark suit, a large dog beside him, every detail rendered with an almost photographic, faintly unsettling sharpness.

Hugo Erfurth with Dog, painted in 1926 by Otto Dix — a leading figure of the *Neue Sachlichkeit*, the "New Objectivity" that followed Expressionism in 1920s Weimar Germany. The sitter, Hugo Erfurth, was a celebrated portrait photographer; Dix paints a fellow image-maker.

After the heat and distortion of the Expressionists, Dix swings to the opposite extreme: a chilly, merciless precision, every wrinkle and hair and thread fixed with the clarity of an old master crossed with a police photograph. Dix had been through the horror of the First World War and came back determined to show the modern world exactly as it was — sober, sharp, stripped of illusion. Even this dignified portrait has an edge of cold scrutiny; the New Objectivity painters trusted appearances precisely because they no longer trusted feelings. Dix once recalled the advice that "everything we Germans paint is a portrait" — and Weimar Germany sat for him without flattery. Within a few years the Nazis would brand his work "degenerate" and hound him from his teaching post. A warmer, more mystical German vision hangs a little further on — Franz Marc, through here.

TRACK 046 · 34 W-FOCUS 201 WORDS · ~2 MIN

Franz Marc, *The Dream*

WHERE YOU ARE

Room 34 — animals and figures dissolving into colour.

WHAT YOU SEE

Franz Marc, *The Dream*, 1912 — oil on canvas.

LISTEN FOR

Marc's belief that colour itself carried meaning — and the dream-world he built from it.

A glowing, dreamlike scene in pure colour — a seated nude woman with her eyes closed, surrounded by animals: horses, a lion, a quiet menagerie in flat zones of blue, red and yellow.

The Dream, painted in 1912 by Franz Marc, one of the founders, with Kandinsky, of *Der Blaue Reiter* — "the Blue Rider" — the more lyrical, spiritual wing of German Expressionism in Munich.

Marc loved animals above all subjects. He believed they were purer, more innocent, more in tune with the rhythms of creation than corrupted modern humans, and he painted them in symbolic colours — blue for the spiritual and masculine, yellow for joy, red for the earthly and violent. Here the sleeping woman and her calm animals seem to dissolve into a single harmonious dream, the boundary between human, beast and world melting away in colour. It's a vision of a lost paradise, an inner Eden — exactly the kind of spiritual renewal the Blue Rider artists hoped art could bring. Tragically, Marc was killed at Verdun in 1916, one of the great talents lost to the First World War. Now the same liberation of colour, in a sunnier French key — Derain, just beyond.

TRACK 047 · 40 W-FOCUS 212 WORDS · ~2 MIN

André Derain, *Waterloo Bridge*

WHERE YOU ARE

Room 40 — a London bridge in shocking, unreal colour.

WHAT YOU SEE

André Derain, *Waterloo Bridge*, 1906 — oil on canvas.

LISTEN FOR

Fauvism at full blast: the same London Monet painted, but in pure wild colour.

A London bridge ablaze with impossible colour — the Thames in hot pinks, oranges and emerald greens, the water a patchwork of pure, unmixed pigment.

Waterloo Bridge, painted in 1906 by André Derain, who with Henri Matisse led the *Fauves* — the "wild beasts," as a shocked critic called them in 1905 for their riotous, unnatural colour. The dealer Ambroise Vollard had sent Derain to London to paint the city; where Monet had wrapped these same bridges in delicate fog, Derain set them on fire.

This is colour cut loose from description. The Fauves took the lesson of Van Gogh and Gauguin — that colour could express feeling rather than copy nature — and pushed it to the limit: here the river is whatever colour the painting needs it to be, laid on in bold, separate strokes of dazzling intensity. It's joyous, daring, almost crude, and utterly modern. Fauvism burned bright for only a few years, but it lit the fuse for everything that followed — it was the first of the twentieth century's great colour revolutions, and Matisse would spend the rest of his life refining what these wild canvases began. After this burst of colour, painting takes its most radical step yet — into pure abstraction, round the corner.

TRACK 048 · 39–43 R-INTRO 176 WORDS · ~1 MIN

Painting lets go of the world: abstraction

WHERE YOU ARE

Rooms 39–43.

WHAT YOU SEE

Kandinsky, El Lissitzky and the first abstract painting.

LISTEN FOR

The moment art stops picturing things and becomes pure shape, colour and rhythm.

Here is one of the boldest leaps in the entire history of art: the moment painting decided it didn't need to depict anything at all.

For five centuries — everything you've seen since those gold-ground panels at the top of the building — painting had been a window onto something: a saint, a face, a landscape, an apple. Then, around 1910–15, a handful of artists asked a dangerous question: what if a painting could be like music — pure colour, line and form, moving you directly, with no subject at all?

Several reached it at once. Wassily Kandinsky, coming out of the Blue Rider, let his forms dissolve into floating colour and gesture. The Dutchman Piet Mondrian stripped everything down to grids of black line and primary colour, hunting for a hidden universal order. And in Russia, a whole explosive avant-garde — Goncharova, Malevich and others — raced toward abstraction in their own way. It was utopian, almost mystical: many believed they were painting a new spiritual age into being. Kandinsky first, a short way on.

TRACK 049 · 39 W-FOCUS 221 WORDS · ~2 MIN

Wassily Kandinsky, *Picture with Three Spots*

WHERE YOU ARE

Room 39, the abstraction rooms — colours and marks floating free.

WHAT YOU SEE

Wassily Kandinsky, *Picture with Three Spots*, 1914 — oil on canvas.

LISTEN FOR

The moment painting lets go of the visible world — and starts behaving like music.

A canvas of floating, colliding colour — three vivid patches anchoring a swirl of line and hue, with no clear "thing" to latch onto.

Picture with Three Spots, painted in 1914 by Wassily Kandinsky, the Russian-born artist usually credited as a founder of abstract art — and a leading light, with Franz Marc, of the Blue Rider. The younger Baron Thyssen bought this canvas in Milan, and it anchors the museum's pioneers-of-abstraction room.

Kandinsky was deeply musical — he experienced colours almost as sounds — and that's the key to him. He came to believe that colours and forms could touch the soul directly, the way a chord or a melody does, with no need to picture a recognisable object in between. So he let the houses and hills and riders of his earlier work dissolve until only the pure visual "music" remained. Don't strain to find a hidden picture here — there isn't one. Let the three spots and the currents of colour around them act on you the way music does when you stop trying to "understand" it and simply listen. He wrote a whole book about it, *Concerning the Spiritual in Art*. Now, a few rooms along, a very different route into abstraction begins — where a Dutchman named Mondrian turns a tree into a grid.

TRACK 050 · 43 W-FOCUS 233 WORDS · ~2 MIN

Piet Mondrian, *Composition No. XIII (Composition 2)*

WHERE YOU ARE

Room 43, the abstraction room — a pale canvas webbed with short black strokes, a tree only half there.

WHAT YOU SEE

Piet Mondrian, *Composition No. XIII (Composition 2)*, 1913 — oil on canvas.

LISTEN FOR

Mondrian years before the famous grids — caught in the act of dissolving a real tree into pure structure.

You probably know Mondrian for the other thing — the white grids ruled into blocks of red, blue and yellow that ended up on everything from cocktail dresses to album covers. This is Mondrian before all of that, and it's the more revealing picture. He painted it in 1913, just after moving to Paris and running headlong into Cubism, and it began life as a tree — most likely a eucalyptus. You can still feel the trunk and the spreading branches in the cage of short black strokes hovering on the pale, ochre-grey ground.

Watch what he's doing to it. He takes one living, particular tree and boils it down to a rhythm of little horizontals and verticals, hunting for the structure underneath the surface. The Cubists had cracked objects into facets; Mondrian goes further, draining the object away until almost nothing is left but a scaffolding of marks, floating free.

This is the hinge of his whole life's work. Within a few years he'll throw out the curve and the diagonal too, keep only the straight line and the three primary colours, and call it Neo-Plasticism — an art he was convinced could show the hidden order of the universe. So you're standing at the exact moment the tree turns into the grid. In this same room the Russian avant-garde takes abstraction somewhere harder and more political — El Lissitzky, just here.

TRACK 051 · 43 W-FOCUS 207 WORDS · ~2 MIN

El Lissitzky, *Proun 1 C*

WHERE YOU ARE

Room 43 — flat geometric shapes hovering on a pale field.

WHAT YOU SEE

El Lissitzky, *Proun 1 C*, c. 1919 — oil on panel.

LISTEN FOR

The Russian avant-garde dream of building a new world out of pure geometry.

A spare, precise abstract composition — geometric forms, bars and planes, hovering in a weightless space that feels part painting, part architectural blueprint.

Proun 1 C, painted around 1919 by El Lissitzky, one of the driving forces of the Russian avant-garde in the white-hot years around the 1917 Revolution. "Proun" was his own invented word — roughly, "project for the affirmation of the new" — for these works he saw as a way-station between painting and architecture.

This is abstraction with a mission. Where Kandinsky chased the spiritual and the Dutchman Mondrian (also in these rooms) hunted a perfect universal balance of line and primary colour, the Russians believed art could literally help *build* a new society. Lissitzky's floating geometric forms aren't meant to depict anything — they're blueprints for a new world, models of a future of pure rational order, rising after the upheaval swept the old one away. For a few electric years Moscow was as radical as anywhere on earth, before Stalin crushed the avant-garde and demanded propaganda instead. You're looking at one of the great hopeful what-ifs of modern art. Now to the movement that broke the world into facets and never put it back the same — Cubism, right along here.

TRACK 052 · 41–42 R-INTRO 170 WORDS · ~1 MIN

Cubism: the world in pieces

WHERE YOU ARE

Rooms 41–42.

WHAT YOU SEE

Picasso, Braque and Juan Gris.

LISTEN FOR

How Cubism shattered the single viewpoint and rebuilt objects from every side at once.

Around 1907, two young painters in Paris — Pablo Picasso and Georges Braque — looked hard at Cézanne's faceted world and then did something no one had dared: they smashed the single, fixed viewpoint that had governed Western painting since the Renaissance.

Their idea was radical and a little dizzying. Instead of painting an object from one spot, frozen in one instant, they walked around it in their minds and put *all* the views down at once — front, side, top — flattened and interlocked on the canvas. A face, a guitar, a bottle would shatter into overlapping planes, the way we actually build up a thing in our minds from many glances over time. They worked so closely in these years, Braque said, that they were "roped together like mountaineers."

It looks difficult, and it was meant to stretch you. But Cubism is the hinge of modern art — almost everything that follows, from abstraction to collage, runs through it. Picasso, the restless giant, first — not far on.

TRACK 053 · 41 W-FOCUS 201 WORDS · ~2 MIN

Pablo Picasso, *Harlequin with a Mirror*

WHERE YOU ARE

Room 41, the Cubist rooms — a harlequin and a faceted mirror.

WHAT YOU SEE

Pablo Picasso, *Harlequin with a Mirror*, 1923 — oil on canvas.

LISTEN FOR

Picasso after Cubism, reaching back to classical order — and the figure he kept returning to.

A solid, calm figure of a harlequin in his diamond-patterned costume, seated before a mirror — monumental and classical, not shattered.

Harlequin with a Mirror, painted in 1923 by Pablo Picasso. It may surprise you, after that Cubism introduction, to find it so legible — but that's Picasso's whole point: having helped *invent* Cubism, he refused to be trapped by it, and in the 1920s swung back toward a serene, sculptural, classical style.

The harlequin — the diamond-clad clown of old Italian theatre — was one of Picasso's lifelong alter egos, and many read this calm figure gazing into a mirror as a kind of veiled self-portrait, the artist contemplating himself and his many masks. After the fracturing of Cubism and the trauma of the First World War, a number of artists made this "return to order," reaching back to classical solidity and calm. But Picasso being Picasso, it was just one room he passed through; over a sixty-year career he reinvented himself again and again — Blue Period, Cubism, Classicism, Surrealism — restless to the end. Here you catch one of his most poised, beautiful moments. His co-inventor Braque, and the more crystalline Gris, are a few steps on.

TRACK 054 · 41–42 W-FOCUS 185 WORDS · ~1 MIN

Braque, Gris and the Cubist tradition

WHERE YOU ARE

Rooms 41–42 — tabletop objects broken into planes.

WHAT YOU SEE

Georges Braque, Juan Gris and the Cubist tradition.

LISTEN FOR

What Cubism became after Picasso — the patient, building work of Braque and Gris.

Cubist still lifes — guitars, bottles, newspaper, the everyday café tabletop broken into interlocking brown and grey planes, sometimes with pasted paper and stencilled letters.

Work by Georges Braque, Picasso's partner in inventing Cubism, and Juan Gris, the Spaniard who became its most lucid third voice.

If Picasso was the wild genius, Braque was the patient craftsman — quieter, more harmonious, deeply in love with the materials of painting. He and Picasso practically merged their identities in the Cubist years, and Braque made some of the key breakthroughs: introducing stencilled lettering, imitation wood-grain, and then *collage* — gluing real scraps of newspaper and wallpaper onto the canvas, a move that detonated centuries of assumptions about what a picture could be made of. Juan Gris, meanwhile, brought a crystalline order and rich colour to Cubism, assembling his objects with the cool precision of an architect. Look for the everyday subjects — the café table, the guitar, the bottle — because Cubism, for all its difficulty, was rooted in ordinary modern life. From the analytical to the irrational: Dada and the dream world of Surrealism, close by.

TRACK 055 · 44 R-INTRO 168 WORDS · ~1 MIN

Dada and the dream: Surrealism

WHERE YOU ARE

Room 44.

WHAT YOU SEE

Dalí, Max Ernst and Yves Tanguy.

LISTEN FOR

How the Surrealists went hunting for the unconscious — by dream, by accident, by chance.

The First World War broke something. Millions dead in the mud for nothing — and to a group of artists, the whole edifice of Western reason and "civilised" values stood exposed as a murderous fraud. Their response was Dada: deliberate nonsense, anti-art, absurdity as protest, mocking a culture that had marched itself into the slaughter.

Out of Dada grew something more lasting — Surrealism. Led by the writer André Breton and electrified by Sigmund Freud's new science of the unconscious, the Surrealists set out to liberate the hidden mind: dreams, desire, the irrational, the things reason keeps locked away. Some, like Dalí, painted hyper-real dreamscapes where impossible things meet with hallucinatory clarity. Others, like Max Ernst and Joan Miró, invented chance techniques and floating biomorphic forms to let the unconscious do the inventing.

It became the most famous avant-garde of all, reshaping art, film, advertising and the way we still talk about dreams. Welcome to the world beneath the rational. Dalí and the dream-painters, a little way on.

TRACK 056 · 44 W-FOCUS 235 WORDS · ~2 MIN

Salvador Dalí, *Dream Caused by the Flight of a Bee around a Pomegranate a Second before Waking*

WHERE YOU ARE

Room 44, the Surrealist rooms — a sleeping nude, a pomegranate, leaping tigers.

WHAT YOU SEE

Salvador Dalí, *Dream Caused by the Flight of a Bee…*, 1944 — oil on canvas.

LISTEN FOR

How Dalí paints the split-second of a dream just before waking — and the science behind it.

A nude woman floating, asleep, just above a flat rock over the sea — and erupting beside her, two tigers and a long bayonet leaping out of a burst pomegranate, with an elephant on impossibly thin legs in the distance.

Dream Caused by the Flight of a Bee around a Pomegranate a Second before Waking, painted in 1944 by Salvador Dalí, the Catalan showman-genius and the most famous Surrealist of all. The sleeping woman is Gala, his wife and muse.

The whole picture is a single instant — the split second before waking — visualised. The long title tells you the trigger: a real bee buzzing around Gala as she naps, its tiny sound bursting in her sleeping mind into this cascade of images. The bayonet about to prick her arm is the sting that will wake her; the leaping tigers come roaring out of a fish out of the pomegranate, dream-logic at full tilt. Dalí called his method "paranoiac-critical" — deliberately courting a waking delirium to dredge up these images, then painting them with old-master precision so the impossible feels disturbingly solid. He was also fascinated by the new science of the atom and by Freud's theory of dreams, and both haunt this canvas. The wildest dream content, delivered with the cool exactitude of a Dutch still life. The other face of Surrealism — chance and the half-formed — is just along here.

TRACK 057 · 44 W-FOCUS 189 WORDS · ~2 MIN

Max Ernst, Tanguy and the Surrealist unconscious

WHERE YOU ARE

Room 44 — eerie, invented dream-landscapes.

WHAT YOU SEE

Max Ernst, Yves Tanguy and the Surrealist unconscious.

LISTEN FOR

The Surrealist techniques for letting the unconscious — not the hand — make the picture.

Strange, hallucinatory canvases — eerie deserted landscapes with unidentifiable forms, or surfaces full of odd textures that seem grown rather than painted.

Work by Max Ernst, Yves Tanguy and other Surrealists who chased the unconscious not through dream-photography like Dalí, but through chance and invented technique.

These artists distrusted the conscious, controlling mind — that was the mind that had built the war. So they invented ways to bypass it. Max Ernst pioneered *frottage* (rubbing paper over textured surfaces to coax up images) and *grattage* (scraping paint), letting accident suggest forests, creatures, ruined worlds. Yves Tanguy painted vast, silent dreamscapes populated by soft, boneless forms that resemble nothing on earth yet feel weirdly alive. The shared goal was *automatism* — making art the way you free-associate or dream, without the editing, planning mind interfering. It can be unsettling, even a little queasy, and that's the intention: you're looking at images dredged from below the surface of thought. After the dream, history comes crashing back — and the centre of art crosses the Atlantic for good. America, abstraction, and the modern condition, just ahead — down toward the last rooms.

TRACK 058 · 46–49 R-INTRO 177 WORDS · ~1 MIN

The centre of art crosses the Atlantic

WHERE YOU ARE

Rooms 46–49.

WHAT YOU SEE

O'Keeffe, Hopper, Pollock and Bacon — mid-century America and Britain.

LISTEN FOR

How New York took over from Paris as the engine of modern art after 1945.

For everything you've seen so far, the capital of Western art was a European city — Florence, Venice, Amsterdam, Paris. In these rooms, that ends. After the Second World War, for the first time, the centre of gravity crosses the ocean and lands in New York.

There were reasons. Fleeing fascism, many of Europe's greatest modern artists had emigrated to the United States in the 1930s and '40s, bringing the whole avant-garde with them. And after the war, a confident, wealthy America was ready to build something new. Out of that came Abstract Expressionism — huge, gestural, ambitious canvases by painters like Jackson Pollock, the first American movement to lead the world rather than follow Europe.

But America had its realists too — Edward Hopper, painting the loneliness inside the modern city — and Europe was far from finished, with figures like Francis Bacon staring unflinchingly at the post-war human animal. These rooms hold some of the Thyssen's most beloved modern works. The quietest of them might be the most famous — Hopper, a little further on.

TRACK 059 · 46 W-FOCUS 207 WORDS · ~2 MIN

Georgia O'Keeffe, *From the Plains II*

WHERE YOU ARE

Room 46 — a huge, abstracted American horizon.

WHAT YOU SEE

Georgia O'Keeffe, *From the Plains II*, 1954 — oil on canvas.

LISTEN FOR

How O'Keeffe turns the memory of cattle and the Texas plains into pure colour and scale.

A vast, simplified American landscape — bands of flaming red, orange and lemon-yellow stretching across a wide horizontal canvas, more sensation than scenery.

From the Plains II, painted in 1954 by Georgia O'Keeffe — the pioneering American modernist — as a second version of a picture she'd first painted thirty-five years earlier, recalling cattle being herded across the Texas plains.

O'Keeffe found abstraction in the real American land rather than importing European theory. Here she takes a memory — the noise and dust of cattle on the vast plains, the flaming colours of a Texas sunset — and distils it into pure colour and horizontal sweep. She said of it that "the color is just plain color out of the tube — red and orange to lemon," and that it almost shocked her. That's the point: she's after the *feeling* of the immense, empty land, not a faithful view of it. O'Keeffe spent decades in New Mexico painting bones, flowers and deserts with this same clean, swelling clarity, going entirely her own way, owing nothing to Paris. A quiet radical who insisted she be seen simply as an artist, not a "woman artist." Now the most famous lonely room in modern art — Hopper, through here.

TRACK 060 · 45 W-FOCUS 234 WORDS · ~2 MIN

Edward Hopper, *Hotel Room*

WHERE YOU ARE

Room 45 — a woman alone in a bare hotel room.

WHAT YOU SEE

Edward Hopper, *Hotel Room*, 1931 — oil on canvas.

LISTEN FOR

The American loneliness Hopper makes out of light, geometry and a dropped letter.

A woman alone on the edge of a bed in a bare hotel room at night, in her slip, head bowed over a sheet of paper, her luggage still packed on the floor.

Hotel Room, painted by Edward Hopper in 1931 — one of the treasures of this museum and one of the defining images of modern American art.

Hopper is the poet of modern loneliness, and this is his masterpiece of it. A woman sits on the bed in an anonymous hotel room; it's night, and she's tired. She has taken off her hat, dress and shoes, and—too exhausted to unpack—she is checking the time of her train the next day. That's the whole "event." But look what Hopper builds from it: the hard geometry of the room, the stark electric light, the heavy shadows, the way she's hemmed in by furniture and walls. Everything is still, silent, suspended. We've all been this person — alone in a strange room far from home, caught in a flat, in-between moment. Hopper never tells you the story; he gives you the mood and lets your own loneliness fill it in. He once said he was just trying to paint sunlight on a wall — but what he really painted was the solitude at the heart of the modern city. It's quiet, and it's devastating. From American silence to American energy — Pollock, just beyond.

TRACK 061 · 48 W-FOCUS 214 WORDS · ~2 MIN

Jackson Pollock, *Brown and Silver I*

WHERE YOU ARE

Room 48 — a dense web of poured silver and brown.

WHAT YOU SEE

Jackson Pollock, *Brown and Silver I*, c. 1951 — enamel and silver on canvas.

LISTEN FOR

What Pollock was actually doing dripping paint on the floor — and why it mattered.

A large canvas that's pure energy — skeins and spatters of poured paint, brown and silver and black, woven into a dense, rhythmic, all-over web with no centre and no edge.

Brown and Silver I, painted around 1951 by Jackson Pollock — "Jack the Dripper," the wild man of Abstract Expressionism and the artist who, more than any other, announced that American painting had arrived.

Pollock did something genuinely new. He took the canvas off the easel, laid it on the floor, and moved *around* and *over* it, flinging, dripping and pouring liquid paint from sticks and brushes, his whole body in motion. The result isn't a picture *of* anything — it's a record of the act of making it, a frozen dance. There's no focal point; the energy spreads edge to edge, "all-over," so your eye keeps roving with no place to rest. Critics called it "action painting": the canvas as an arena for an event rather than a surface for an image. It looks like chaos, but stand with it and a strange, taut order emerges — rhythm, density, control inside the abandon. This was the moment European artists started watching New York. The other side of the post-war coin — Europe's tortured human figure, Bacon — is round the corner.

TRACK 062 · 49 W-FOCUS 227 WORDS · ~2 MIN

Francis Bacon, *Portrait of George Dyer in a Mirror*

WHERE YOU ARE

Room 49 — a contorted man and his reflection in a round mirror.

WHAT YOU SEE

Francis Bacon, *Portrait of George Dyer in a Mirror*, 1968 — oil on canvas.

LISTEN FOR

Bacon's lover, the warped mirror, and the violence Bacon finds in a single human face.

A lone man twisted in a round-backed chair, his face and body smeared and distorted, his reflection in a mirror behind him just as broken — caged in a bare, airless space.

Portrait of George Dyer in a Mirror, painted in 1968 by Francis Bacon, the British painter who stared harder at the post-war human animal than almost anyone. George Dyer was Bacon's lover and his most painted model — a relationship as turbulent as the paint.

While the Americans next door went abstract, Bacon stayed brutally figurative — but his figures are like nothing before him. He smears and wrenches Dyer's face and body until the man seems caught mid-motion, mid-dissolve, raw flesh trapped in cold geometric space and doubled in an unforgiving mirror. After the death camps and the atomic bomb, Bacon painted the human being stripped of comfort and dignity. Yet he revered the old masters — Velázquez above all — so even at his most savage he's in dialogue with the tradition hanging upstairs. There's real tenderness buried in the violence here, too: this is someone he loved. A few years later Dyer would die, and Bacon would paint his grief for the rest of his life. Hard to look at, hard to look away from. After this existential weight, art gets loud, bright and ironic — Pop, a short way on.

TRACK 063 · 52–56 R-INTRO 160 WORDS · ~1 MIN

Pop: art eats the supermarket

WHERE YOU ARE

Rooms 52–56.

WHAT YOU SEE

Lichtenstein and Rauschenberg — American Pop.

LISTEN FOR

How art swallowed advertising, comics and consumer junk — and called it the new reality.

After the heavy seriousness of the post-war years — all that angst and abstraction — a younger generation in the late 1950s and '60s did something cheeky and revolutionary: they let the everyday consumer world flood straight into art.

This was Pop. Instead of tortured souls or pure abstraction, here were comic strips, soup cans, advertisements, film stars, packaging — the bright, mass-produced imagery of modern consumer life, presented deadpan and huge. Was it a celebration of this new abundance, or a cool critique of its shallowness? Pop was deliberately ambiguous, and that ambiguity was the point. It blurred the line between high art and low commercial culture until you couldn't tell where one stopped and the other began.

It was mostly an Anglo-American explosion — Warhol, Lichtenstein and Rauschenberg in New York foremost among them — and it changed art's relationship with everyday life forever. After Pop came its many afterlives, the "Postpop" rooms beyond. Lichtenstein first, over here.

TRACK 064 · 52 W-FOCUS 189 WORDS · ~2 MIN

Roy Lichtenstein, *Woman in Bath*

WHERE YOU ARE

Room 52, the Pop rooms — a comic-strip woman in a bath.

WHAT YOU SEE

Roy Lichtenstein, *Woman in Bath*, 1963 — oil and magna on canvas.

LISTEN FOR

How Lichtenstein blows up cheap print — Ben-Day dots and all — into high art.

A big, flat, comic-book image — a woman rendered in bold black outlines, primary colour, and those unmistakable rows of mechanical printed dots.

Woman in Bath, painted in 1963 by Roy Lichtenstein, who, with Andy Warhol, became the face of American Pop Art by stealing his style straight from the comics and advertisements.

Lichtenstein took the lowest, most disposable imagery imaginable — cheap romance and war comics — and blew it up to the scale of history painting, copying even the crude printing process: the heavy black outlines, the flat zones of primary colour, and above all the *Ben-Day dots*, the little mechanical dots that comic printers used for shading, which he painted painstakingly by hand. The effect is deadpan and witty: a throwaway image, monumentalised and frozen, forcing you to ask what makes one image "art" and another mere commerce. Is he mocking mass culture or loving it? Both, and neither — that cool refusal to tell you is pure Pop. There's real formal beauty in the precision, too. From the comics to the junk-and-image collisions of Rauschenberg and the Postpop rooms — right along here.

TRACK 065 · 53–56 W-FOCUS 239 WORDS · ~2 MIN

Robert Rauschenberg, *Express*

WHERE YOU ARE

Rooms 53–56 — a sprawling collage of silkscreened images.

WHAT YOU SEE

Robert Rauschenberg, *Express*, 1963 — oil and silkscreen on canvas.

LISTEN FOR

How Rauschenberg floods the canvas with the noise of modern America.

A big, restless canvas in the final rooms — a teeming collage of silkscreened photographs (a horse and rider mid-jump, dancers, a climber, a nude descending a staircase) overlaid with bold, rapid brushstrokes.

Express, made in 1963 by Robert Rauschenberg — one of his most important works and a treasure of this collection. It's among the first paintings in which he used silkscreen to print photographic images straight onto the canvas. (The museum is marking Rauschenberg's centenary with a special display devoted to this very painting.)

Rauschenberg said he wanted to work "in the gap between art and life," and *Express* lives right in that gap. He bridged the older Abstract Expressionists and the young Pop artists — keeping their gestural brushwork while flooding the canvas with the mass-media imagery of modern life. The title hints at speed and movement, and the picture is full of it: the leaping horse, the dancers, the wheels, the figure descending the stair, all enlarged to a grainy, newsprint roughness and woven together so your eye keeps moving, never settling. You've travelled a long way from Duccio's gold leaf at the top of the building — from a single sacred image made for prayer to a swirling overload of media imagery made for a world drowning in pictures. That whole journey is the point. One more floor to go — a second, gentler collection waits below. This way, down to Level 0.

TRACK 066 · ROOMS A–J R-INTRO 196 WORDS · ~2 MIN

A second collection, a second eye

WHERE YOU ARE

The Carmen Thyssen rooms (A onward).

WHAT YOU SEE

Gauguin, Constable, Goncharova and the Baroness's own collection.

LISTEN FOR

How a second collection, with a different taste, rounds out the museum's story.

One more floor — and a lovely surprise to end on. Level 0 holds a separate collection with its own personality: the Carmen Thyssen Collection, assembled by Carmen "Tita" Cervera, the Spanish former beauty queen who married the last Baron and became the great champion of keeping all this art in Madrid.

It began as an extension of the family collection and grew into something distinctly hers. Where the Baron's taste ranged encyclopaedically across all of art history, the Baroness followed her heart — toward landscape, toward colour, toward beauty and pleasure. So this floor is gentler and sunnier than the rooms above: arcadian landscapes, glowing Impressionist and Post-Impressionist scenes, nineteenth-century American vistas, early modern colour.

Think of it as a second, more personal walk through some of the same centuries you've just travelled — a coda in a warmer key. It's smaller and easier on tired feet, and it holds at least one undisputed masterpiece that many visitors rank among their favourites in the whole museum. After the long descent through the history of everything, this is the part you can simply enjoy. The jewel of it — a Gauguin — is just along here.

TRACK 067 · ROOM F W-FOCUS 229 WORDS · ~2 MIN

Paul Gauguin, *Mata Mua (In Olden Times)*

WHERE YOU ARE

Room F, the Carmen Thyssen collection — a Tahitian scene in flat, glowing colour.

WHAT YOU SEE

Paul Gauguin, *Mata Mua (In Olden Times)*, 1892 — oil on canvas.

LISTEN FOR

The paradise Gauguin invented in Tahiti, and the myth he painted over the reality.

A radiant tropical scene — a great blue idol on the left, women in a lush Tahitian landscape, one playing a flute, all in deep, saturated, unreal colour.

Mata Mua — In Olden Times — painted by Paul Gauguin in 1892, during his first stay in Tahiti. It's the crown jewel of the Carmen Thyssen Collection and one of the best-loved paintings in the museum.

Gauguin had fled Europe — its cities, its industry, its art world — convinced that "civilisation" was a sickness and that truth and beauty survived only in places he imagined as untouched and primal. In Tahiti he painted not so much what he found as what he longed for: an idyllic, mythic, pre-colonial paradise that, in truth, had already largely vanished under European contact. The blue figure is an idol, the moon goddess Hina; the title looks back nostalgically to "olden times." Look at the colour — laid down in flat, bold, non-natural zones, the grass pink, the shadows blue — and the dreamy, decorative calm. This break from realistic colour and his hunger for the "primitive" made Gauguin a crucial bridge to twentieth-century art; Matisse and the Expressionists upstairs owe him a great deal. It's gorgeous and, knowing the colonial reality behind the dream, a little complicated — which only makes it richer. Two more highlights of the Baroness's eye are just ahead.

TRACK 068 · ROOMS B–E W-FOCUS 213 WORDS · ~2 MIN

John Constable and the Baroness's landscapes

WHERE YOU ARE

Rooms B–E, Carmen Thyssen — English skies and green country.

WHAT YOU SEE

John Constable and the Baroness's landscapes.

LISTEN FOR

How Constable made plain English weather feel monumental — and worth collecting.

A luminous English landscape — green countryside under a big, restless sky full of moving cloud, a river or a mill, painted with fresh, flickering touches of light.

A landscape by John Constable, one of the jewels of the Carmen Thyssen Collection and the heart of the Baroness's love of landscape painting. Constable, working in early-nineteenth-century England, is one of the two great English landscape masters alongside Turner.

Constable did something quietly revolutionary: he painted the ordinary working countryside of his native Suffolk — the River Stour, its locks and mills and hay wagons — with a truthfulness and freshness nobody had brought to it before. He studied clouds like a scientist, filling the sky with weather you can almost feel, and he built his greens and lights from broken, flickering touches of paint that seemed crude to his contemporaries and prophetic to ours. When his work was shown in Paris it stunned the French and helped light the way toward the Impressionists you saw upstairs. This whole floor doubles down on the Thyssen's quiet strength — landscape — chosen by the Baroness for its light and loveliness rather than to fill a textbook. Let your eye rest in it. One last jewel, and then out into Madrid — a little further on.

TRACK 069 · ROOMS H–I W-FOCUS 209 WORDS · ~2 MIN

Natalia Goncharova, *Fishing*

WHERE YOU ARE

Rooms H–I, Carmen Thyssen — fishermen and nets in bold colour.

WHAT YOU SEE

Natalia Goncharova, *Fishing*, c. 1909 — oil on canvas.

LISTEN FOR

The Russian avant-garde woman who fused folk art and modern colour into something new.

A bold, vigorous canvas of fishermen at work — figures and nets and water broken into rhythmic, faceted forms, in strong, earthy, folk-bright colour.

Fishing (also called *Fishers*), painted in 1909 by Natalia Goncharova, one of the leaders of the explosive Russian avant-garde — held here as part of the Carmen Thyssen Collection, a fitting modern jewel to close on.

Goncharova matters twice over. As an artist, she fused the newest Western ideas — Cézanne's faceting, the Cubists' broken form, the Futurists' love of energy — with something deeply Russian: the bold colour, flat patterning and earthy subjects of folk art, popular prints and icons. The result, as here, is modern and ancient at once, sophisticated and rooted in the soil. And as a woman, she was a genuine *leader* of the avant-garde, not a footnote — provocative, prolific, internationally famous, later designing for the Ballets Russes in Paris. It's a fitting place to end, because it calmly rhymes with everything upstairs: the early-twentieth-century moment when colour and form broke free, sampled once more through one collector's eye. You've now seen all of it, top to bottom — seven centuries, two collections, one continuous story. Take a breath. Then let's step back out into Madrid — this way.

TRACK 070 · CLOSING CLOSE 234 WORDS · ~2 MIN

Out into the Paseo del Arte

And there it is — seven centuries, one staircase, one afternoon. You've walked from a Sienese altarpiece glowing with gold leaf all the way down to Pop Art and a lonely woman in a hotel room, and if you did it top to bottom, you did it exactly as the family who built this collection intended: as one continuous story, with no chapter missing.

That's the quiet genius of this place. The Prado will show you the summits of Spanish and royal painting; the Reina Sofía will show you what Spain did to the twentieth century. But only here can you stand in front of Van Eyck in the morning and Pollock by mid-afternoon and feel the through-line — the slow, restless, endlessly inventive business of human beings trying to put the world onto a flat surface.

Step outside onto the Paseo del Prado. You're standing on the spine of the Golden Triangle: the Prado is just up the boulevard, the Reina Sofía down toward Atocha, and the great green lung of the Retiro is a short walk east. If your feet are tired, the Thyssen's own café in the courtyard is one of the calmer spots in the city to sit and let it all settle.

Whatever you do next, you've just done something rare — you've seen the whole arc, start to finish. Take it with you. Safe travels, and enjoy Madrid.

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